

Renting on the Island of Ireland

*An All-Island Survey of Private Rented
Sector Tenants*

Dr. Kevin Cunningham
Ben Heskin
January 2026

**Housing
Rights**


Threshold
preventing homelessness



An Roinn Gnóthaí
Eachtracha agus Trádála
Department of
Foreign Affairs and Trade

Renting on the Island of Ireland

*An All-Island Survey of Private Rented
Sector Tenants*

A report from:



**Housing
Rights**

Kindly funded by:



An Roinn Gnóthaí
Eachtracha agus Trádála
Department of
Foreign Affairs and Trade

Acknowledgements

In 2025, Threshold and Housing Rights commissioned Ireland Thinks to undertake an all-island study of the private rental sector. The report was authored by Dr Kevin Cunningham, with valuable research support from Ben Heskin.

We want to express our sincere gratitude to all those who participated in the research, including respondents to the public opinion survey and the individuals who generously contributed their time and insights through in-depth interviews.

We extend our thanks to Ann-Marie O'Reilly, Gareth Redmond, John-Mark McCafferty and Emily Power of Threshold, and to Stephen Morrison, Jamie Miller and Kate McCauley of Housing Rights, for all of their insights, guidance, direction and support throughout the entire project. Thanks also to Marianne Hennessy and Cat Clark at Threshold for editing and designing the preview of the results report, published in November 2025 as part of the Housing Rights annual conference.

Finally, we gratefully acknowledge the contribution of the research advisory group: Karen Barr (Department for Communities), Paddy Gray (Ulster University), Roslyn Molloy (Housing Agency), Brigitte Anton and Amy Thornton. Their expertise and feedback were invaluable to the development of this work.

Glossary of Terms

- **All-Island:** Refers to the geographic area comprising both the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI)
- **Affordability:** The extent to which housing costs are manageable relative to a household's income.
- **Cost Rental (ROI):** A form of state-supported rental housing where rents are based on the cost of delivering and maintaining the dwellings rather than market rates.
- **Intermediate Rent (NI):** A form of affordable housing rental product in respect of the Northern Ireland housing market and provided in accordance with the Department for Communities' Intermediate Rent Policy.
- **Deposit Protection Scheme (DPS) (NI):** A statutory system in Northern Ireland requiring landlords to lodge tenants' deposits with an approved independent scheme.
- **Guarantor:** A person who agrees to take responsibility for a tenant's rent or liabilities if the tenant is unable to meet them. Commonly requested by private landlords in Northern Ireland.
- **HAP (ROI):** The Housing Assistance Payment. A government subsidy in the Republic of Ireland that supports eligible low-income households in securing private rented accommodation. Payments are made to landlords through local authorities, with tenants contributing a differential rent.
- **Minimum Standards:** Legal and regulatory requirements governing the condition of rental properties, incorporating structural integrity, safety, heating and ventilation.
- **No-Fault Eviction:** This is when a tenant is compelled to leave a property for reasons unrelated to their conduct, such as the landlord selling the property, moving back in or changing its use.
- **Periodic Tenancy (NI):** A tenancy that continues on a rolling basis, typically month-to-month, after the initial lease expires, offering fewer protections than fixed-term agreements.
- **Private Rental Sector (PRS):** Housing rented from private landlords, distinct from social or not-for-profit housing.

- **Rent Arrears:** Rental payments that are overdue or unpaid.
- **Rent Pressure Zone (RPZ) (ROI):** Designated areas in the Republic of Ireland where rent increases are capped according to legal limits.
- **RTB:** Residential Tenancy Board
- **Security of Tenure:** The degree of stability and protection a tenant has in their rented home, including notice periods, the term of a lease and eviction protections.
- **Social Housing:** Housing owned or managed by public authorities or not-for-profit organisations, typically allocated to households with lower incomes or specific needs.
- **Universal Credit (UC) (NI):** A UK-wide social welfare payment that combines various supports into a single payment. In Northern Ireland, it can include a housing component to assist with rent.

Table of Contents

About this Report.....	6
Methodology	7
Profile of Respondents.....	8
Reason for renting	9
Qualitative research on reasons for renting.....	11
Preferences and expectations.....	12
Expectations explained.....	16
Outside the rental market.....	16
Qualitative research on preferences & expectations.....	17
Security of Tenure.....	20
Time spent renting	20
Churn in the rental market	22
Reasons for moving	24
Outside the rental market.....	26
Qualitative research on security of tenure	31
Access to the Rental Market	33
Difficulty securing accommodation	33
Documentation necessary to secure housing	35
Outside the rental market.....	36
Affordability & Financial Pressure	39
Share of income spent on rent	40
Ability to pay bills	41
Rent arrears	43
Rights & Protections	48
Knowledge of rights	48
Qualitative research on rights.....	52
Deposit protection scheme.....	53
Repairs & Landlord Relations	58
Outstanding repairs	58
Reporting issues	61
Landlord relations.....	63
Overall Experience	66
Overall experience.....	66
Former renters	69
What would make renting better	71
Conclusion	72

About this Report

This research, commissioned by Threshold and Housing Rights, examines the lived reality of renting across the island of Ireland.

We aim to equip decision-makers, advocates and practitioners with robust evidence to support effective action.

By combining statistical findings with qualitative testimonies, the research reveals a lived experience of renters, grounded in data and hard evidence.

We also aim to give voice to the experiences of 'Generation Rent', with the report highlighting both their aspirations and frustrations.

We conducted two large representative public opinion polls of renters in the private rental sector. One of those was in the Republic of Ireland (ROI), and the other was in Northern Ireland (NI).

This research was combined with in-depth qualitative interviews to produce a comparative study of renting in ROI and NI.

Together, these methods provide a detailed and comparative picture of renting experiences across the two jurisdictions.

The report proceeds thematically. We begin with renters' expectations and aspirations: why they rent and whether they want to own a home.

Then, we explore the challenges of securing a tenancy, specifically how difficult it was and what was required of prospective tenants. Here, we compare the results of existing tenants with those of a small sample of people living at home who are unable to access the rental market.

We then investigate the financial pressures that renters face. This includes a thorough analysis of the share of income renters pay and the extent to which rental payments put pressure on their personal finances.

Next, we cover their knowledge of their rights across a range of policy areas. This also includes an in-depth analysis of the operation of deposit protection schemes.

Finally, we examine the prevalence and resolution of repair issues as they arise in rental accommodation. We also explore the tenant-landlord relationship and the overall experience in the sector.

Methodology

Survey participants were recruited through the Ireland Thinks proprietary online research panel. In total, 1,380 adults took part: 880 in ROI and 500 in NI.

These sample sizes provide margins of error of ± 3.4 percentage points for ROI, ± 4.5 percentage points for NI and ± 2.7 percentage points for the combined all-island sample, based on a 95% confidence level. Please note that the margin of error varies with the reference statistic; for example, the margin of error for a statistic as small as 5% is $\pm 1.9\%$ in NI and $\pm 1.4\%$ in ROI.

This level of statistical precision ensures that the findings are sufficiently robust and can be used with confidence to inform policy design and decision-making across both jurisdictions.

Results for each jurisdiction were weighted separately to ensure they accurately represent the adult population by age, gender and region. The combined all-island results were then adjusted to reflect population proportions, with a weighting of 74% for ROI and 26% for NI.

Qualitative fieldwork was conducted in ROI and NI. Thirteen private-sector renters were recruited for this from individuals who had responded to the survey. Seven of these were renters in ROI, and six were renters from NI. All participants were rewarded for their participation in the research.

Our semi-structured interviews were conducted one-to-one with each participant to better understand their lived experiences and attitudes, and to clarify the survey data. Those interviews were conducted via an online video platform.

All interviews followed a common topic guide, were audio-recorded with consent and transcribed verbatim for subsequent analysis.

Additional research was conducted with two further groups of people who had previously been in the private rental sector but had since left. We focused first on adults who are now living with their parents. We collected a sample of 397, of whom 185 had previously rented. The second group consisted of homeowners, of whom 626 had prior experience in the private rental sector. This additional research was conducted only in the ROI.

Please note that, due to rounding, some totals in this report may appear to add to slightly more or less than 100%.



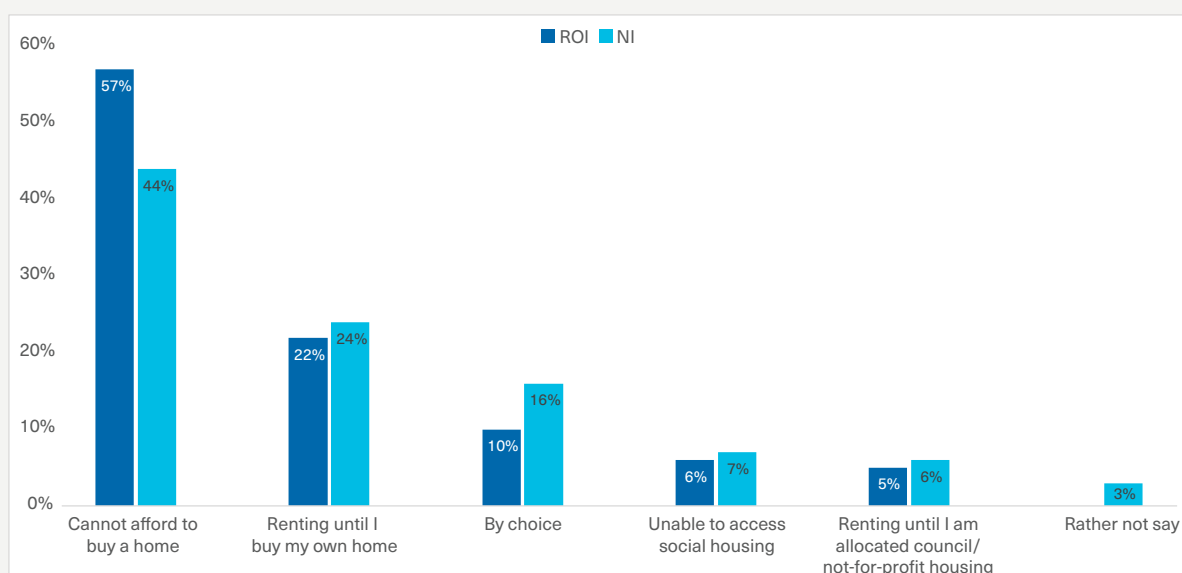
Aspirations & Expectations

Research on housing in Ireland often reveals a deep-rooted aspiration for homeownership. It can be argued that this attitude has been shaped by state policy as much as by culture. Public policy in the Republic of Ireland has promoted homeownership through subsidies, local authority sales and state-backed lending, thereby embedding it as a social expectation (Norris, 2016).¹ In Northern Ireland, UK policy, specifically the Right to Buy, contributed to a decline in public-sector renting and a rise in private renting (Mac Flynn, 2018).²

Reason for renting

The survey asked renters why they are currently renting their homes, allowing them to select one reason from a set of options. The findings show that most people rent out of necessity rather than by choice. Across the island of Ireland, the most common reason for renting is that renters cannot afford to buy a home (53%). The second most common reason is that they are renting until they can buy their own home, with nearly a quarter (23%) giving this response.

Figure 2. Reason for renting in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – 'Why do you rent your home?'



¹ Norris, M. (2016). Varieties of home ownership: Ireland's transition from a socialised to a marketised policy regime. *Housing Studies*, 31(1), 81-101.

² Mac Flynn, P. (2018) Housing Tenure in Northern Ireland: Generational change. NERI Research in Brief, August 2018 (No. 60). Nevin Economic Research Institute (NERI). Available at: https://www.nerinstitute.net/sites/default/files/research/housing_inbrief.pdf

While there is arguably some overlap between the options available, we could infer from the data a distinctive difference in expectations between those who indicated that they were ‘renting until they buy a home’ and those who say they ‘cannot afford to buy a home’. The latter is arguably more pessimistic and represents the majority of renters. To this end, it is worth acknowledging sustained increases in house prices in recent years. In the Republic of Ireland, data from the property price index show a 50% increase over the five years from January 2020 to September 2025. This reflects a decline in relative affordability as incomes have increased by roughly 17% over the same period.³ In Northern Ireland, the rise over the same period was quite similar at 45%, reflecting the rate at which Northern Ireland is catching up with the Republic of Ireland. As we go further back, we can see how the situation in ROI has been worse for longer. Over the ten years since July 2015, prices in ROI have increased by over 100% (effectively doubling), while in Northern Ireland the rise over the same period was 74%. Compared to their peaks, Northern Ireland properties remain 10% lower than 2007, whereas properties in the Republic of Ireland are 24% higher than 2007.

A much smaller group (11%) say they rent by choice, while 6% are waiting to be allocated social or not-for-profit housing. Another 6% said they rent because they are unable to access social housing. While it may seem surprising that so few respondents are renting by choice, previous research shows this is not unusual. In the UK, the British Social Attitudes survey shows similar results. In 2018, just 21% of UK renters preferred to rent, with the remainder preferring to buy; by 2023, those choosing to rent had fallen to 13%.

Comparing ROI and NI, there are modest differences between the two jurisdictions in terms of reasons for renting. In ROI, 57% of current renters say they are renting because they cannot afford to buy, compared with 44% in NI. Renters in NI are also more likely to describe their situation as a matter of choice by a margin of 16% to 10%; this difference is statistically significant.⁴ While the difference between ROI and NI is quite modest, the situation in ROI appears slightly worse for renters. This reflects a theme that we will observe throughout this report.

In terms of demographics, the share of renters who say they are renting until they can buy a home decreases steadily with age and rises with income. This reflects renters’ future expectations, which will be discussed later in the report. There were also some slight differences between men and women. Across the island, women were 9% more likely to indicate they were renting because they could not afford to buy. Men were more likely to report renting by choice or as a temporary measure until they could buy their own home.

³ <https://www.statista.com/statistics/416212/average-annual-wages-ireland-y-on-y-in-euros>

⁴ From a two-sample test, these figures are statistically significant at the 0.001 level.

Qualitative research on reasons for renting

While it is clear that the majority would prefer homeownership over renting, respondents can identify certain advantages to renting. In ROI, these perceived benefits tend to relate to freedom from maintenance responsibilities and the absence of property-related taxes:

“Your pros are if the boiler breaks, I just have to make a phone call. Someone else comes to fix the boiler. It’s not necessarily my responsibility. It’s not coming out of my pocket.”

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Despite these advantages, the appeal of homeownership lies mainly in its promise of security and stability:

“I know my landlord. If something is broken, he will fix it... I don’t have to worry about paying for it. I don’t have to pay any local property tax. The need to own seems ingrained in the Irish psyche. It’s not that I want to own my own place, to say I own my own place. It’s the fact that I can be turfed out whenever my landlord feels like it. It’s got nothing to do with so-called wasted money. It’s the insecurity. I can’t guarantee I’ll still be here in a year’s time.”

— Nicola, Republic of Ireland

“There’s not that sense of security that perhaps we grew up with where you had one or two houses, but you always went to a better place. Now there isn’t that progression for renters.”

— Triona, Republic of Ireland

“I’d prefer to own my own home, to have security for the kids. It’s like throwing money away that I could be spending on my own home. At least I’d have something to show for it.”

— Niall, Republic of Ireland

Concerns about poor housing standards and unresponsive landlords also fuel the desire for homeownership:

“They act like they’re doing you a favour when you hand over that money, and for most of them, they don’t actually provide the service. I’ve lived in mould, I’ve had ceilings fall through, loads of things break, and they were always resistant to fixing it.”

— Dylan, Republic of Ireland

However, a small number of renters said that they would be content to rent indefinitely if long-term security of tenure were guaranteed:

“If I could rent for life, that would do me. If you could rent somewhere for life and have that security, people wouldn’t be so focused on buying. If rent just increased modestly with inflation, at least you’d always have a roof over your head.”

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Renters in NI were more likely to express interest in long-term renting. They were generally less likely to view renting as a failure or a temporary compromise. And while most still aspired to own their own home, many saw it as a practical, even desirable, if it came with affordability and predictability.

“The one thing that I want is security. I could have that security through social housing.”

— Stephen, Northern Ireland

“Yes, it is something I have chosen to do. [Renting] gives you that much more flexibility.”

— Oliver, Northern Ireland

“To rent from the Housing Association or something, where you were getting that kind of security, absolutely! Compared to private renting or something, absolutely.”

— Sarah, Northern Ireland

Preferences and expectations

A common theme across the island is the gap between renters’ aspirations for where they would like to live in five years’ time versus more realistic expectations of where they see themselves actually living.

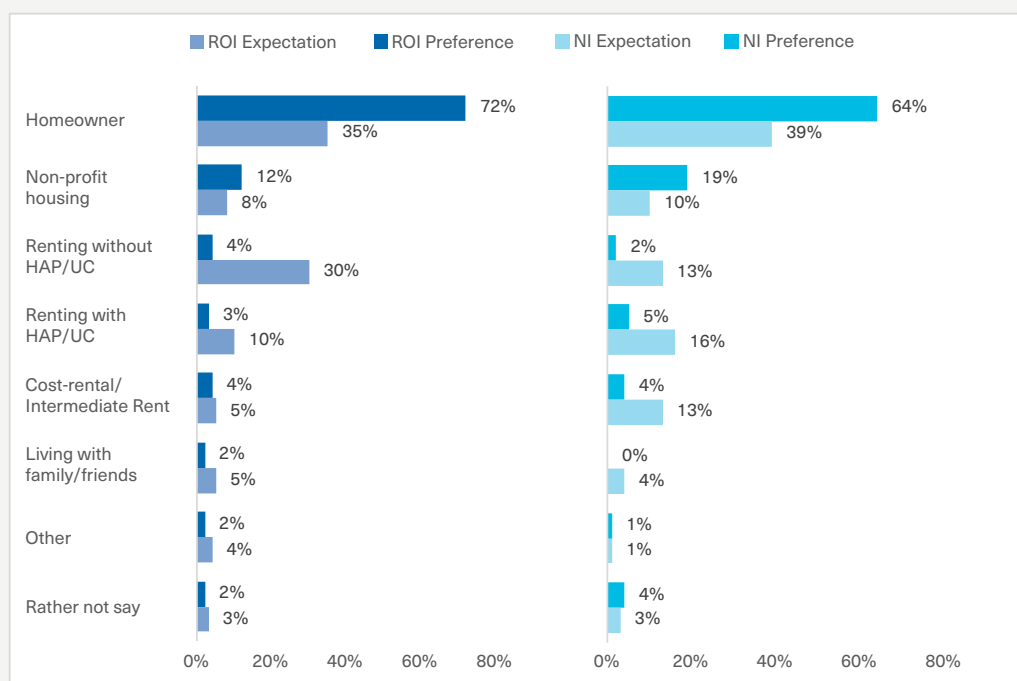
Previous research, such as the 2023 RTB Tenants Report⁵ explored this topic, asking renters where they “see themselves living in the future”. However, while this question addresses renter expectations, it does not address preferences. Threshold’s 2024 We Are

⁵ Residential Tenancies Board (2023) Tenants Research Report: December 2023, available at: <https://rtb.ie/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/RTB-Tenants-Research-Survey-2023-Report-13.12.23.V1.pdf>

Generation Rent survey⁶ made this distinction explicit, asking respondents first what type of accommodation they would prefer to live in and, secondly, what type of accommodation they expect to live in. This revealed a significant gap between preferences and expectations of renters. We have replicated this line of questioning for the all-island survey.

Across the island of Ireland, 70% of renters would prefer to be living in their own home in five years' time. However, only 36% expect to achieve this aspiration. There are significant differences between NI and ROI in terms of preferences, with a larger proportion of renters in ROI (72%) preferring to become homeowners compared with renters in NI (64%). In terms of expectations, more renters in NI actually expect to become homeowners (39%) compared with ROI (35%). An expectations gap is determined by subtracting the number of people who prefer to own their home from those who expect to do so. In ROI, the gap is 37%, compared with 25% in NI. This reflects the earlier result, which showed that a higher share of renters in NI are doing so by choice.

Figure 3. Preferences and expectations of renters in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) vs Northern Ireland (NI) – 'In what type of accommodation [do you expect/would you prefer] to be living in, in five years?'



Note: This question varied by jurisdiction, with the following response options in Northern Ireland (NI) and the Republic of Ireland (ROI). NI: Housing Executive/Housing Association/Council/Non-profit housing; Renting with UC (Universal Credit); Renting without UC (Universal Credit); Intermediate Rent. ROI: Council/Not-for-profit housing; Renting without HAP (Housing Assistance Payment); Renting with HAP (Housing Assistance Payment); Cost-Rental.

⁶ Threshold (2024) We Are Generation Rent 2024, available at: <https://threshold.ie/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/We-Are-Generation-Rent-2024.pdf>

Across the island, 14% of renters would prefer to live in council or not-for-profit housing, with 9% expecting this in five years' time. In NI, a larger share of renters both prefer and expect to live in council housing, perhaps reflecting the higher share of social housing in NI. A much smaller 4% would prefer to live in cost-rental (ROI) or intermediate-rent housing (NI). A larger 13% indicated that they would expect to live in Intermediate rent. This is somewhat higher than expected, and perhaps there is some confusion about what this implies. Only 6% of current renters indicate that they would like to still be renting in the private rental sector in five years' time: 3% want to continue renting with the housing assistance payment (HAP) or Universal Credit (UC), and 3% without HAP or UC.

Further analysis also reveals differences between demographic groups. Across both jurisdictions, income and age affect both the expectations and preferences of renters. Both younger respondents and those on higher incomes were more likely to expect to own their own home. However, there are subtle differences in these patterns between the two jurisdictions. In NI, just over half (52%) of those aged 18 to 34 expect to become homeowners, compared with a third (33%) in ROI. In ROI, the most common expectation for 18-34-year-old renters was to be renting without HAP in five years' time (37%). Relatively few expect to be renting with HAP (8%), or availing of council/not-for-profit housing (4%). This reflects the phenomenon known as 'generation rent', the idea that much of that generation is likely to remain in the private rental sector, perhaps indefinitely (Howard, 2025).⁷

Older renters (aged 45+) were much less likely to believe that they would be homeowners (25%), and more likely to believe that they would be renting with HAP (18%), or living in housing provided for by the council/not-for-profit (20%). Of renters aged 65 or over, 41% expect to be in council or not-for-profit housing, 31% with HAP, and just 10% expect to be renting without HAP.

This increased precarity with age is also clear in NI. Of those aged 45+ in NI, 21% expect to be homeowners, 30% expect to rent with universal credit, and 15% expect to be availing of accommodation provided for by the NI Housing Executive or Housing Association.

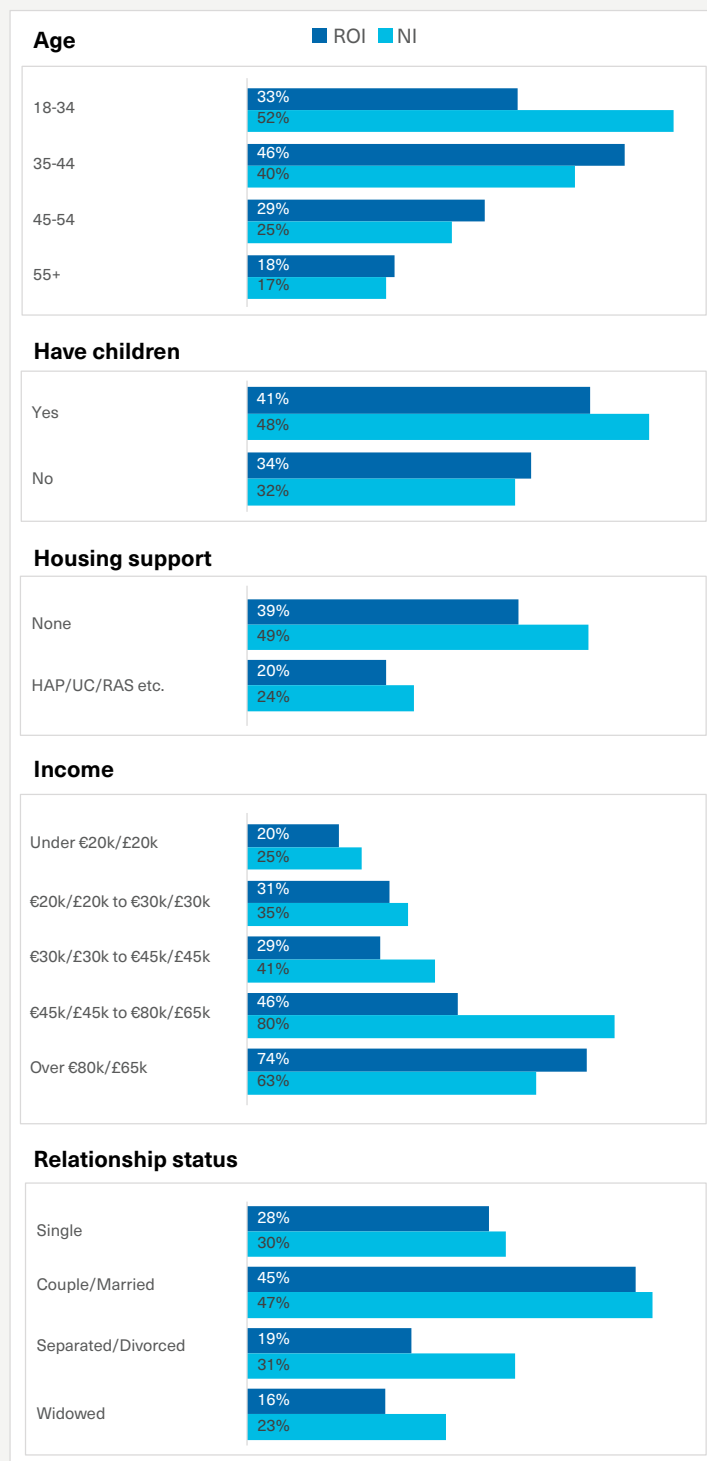
Many of those currently availing of supports expect to continue to do so. In ROI, of those who are currently availing of HAP, 44% expect to still be receiving HAP in five years' time, while 25% expect to be in social housing. In NI, the figures are somewhat similar, with 43% of those availing of UC expecting to be in the same situation in five years. Yet, many fewer (6%) expect to avail of Housing Executive/Housing Association accommodation.

Relationship status also affected expectations of homeownership. Just 24% of lone renters expect to become homeowners. We also observe very low expectations among single-income households, reflecting the fact that two incomes are increasingly seen to be a prerequisite for purchasing a home (e.g. Tedin and Faubert's 2020 research⁸).

⁷ Howard, A. (2025). Seven propositions about 'generation rent'. *Housing, Theory and Society*, 42(1), 1-22.

⁸ Tedin, M. J. D., & Faubert, V. (2020). *Housing Affordability in Ireland* (No. 061). Directorate General Economic and Financial Affairs (DG ECFIN), European Commission.

Figure 4: Expectations for homeownership by demographic group in Northern Ireland (NI) and the Republic of Ireland (ROI).



Note: The chart gives the percentage of respondents who answered 'Homeowner' to the following question: 'In what type of accommodation do you EXPECT to be living in in five years' time?'

Expectations explained

Survey respondents could provide an open-ended text response to explain their reasoning behind their housing expectations. Some comments were positive, where tenants felt secure due to a long lease or a good landlord. Others expressed their hopes or plans to buy a home. However, the dominant theme was one of constrained aspiration. While it was clear that most renters wanted to own their own home, they felt this was unattainable financially due to current market conditions. Illustrative responses included:

- “My expectations are very low that the housing crisis will be fixed.”
- “Ideally would love to be living in my own home but seems increasingly impossible.”
- “Would love to own a house but it’s too hard to rent and save a deposit in the current climate.”

Several respondents remarked that mortgage repayments would be less costly compared to paying rent. However, as one respondent mentioned, saving for a deposit while renting is “very, very difficult when you’re paying astronomical prices.” There were many references to high property prices and the deposits. Others mentioned relationship status, feeling it was difficult to save a deposit or apply for a mortgage on a single income. Many respondents felt resigned to remaining in the private rental sector for the foreseeable future. Some expressed concern over the risk of slipping into homelessness, writing: “Homeless accommodation is more likely” and “Hopefully not homeless.” Some also indicated that they were either planning to emigrate or actively considering it as a response to housing pressures.

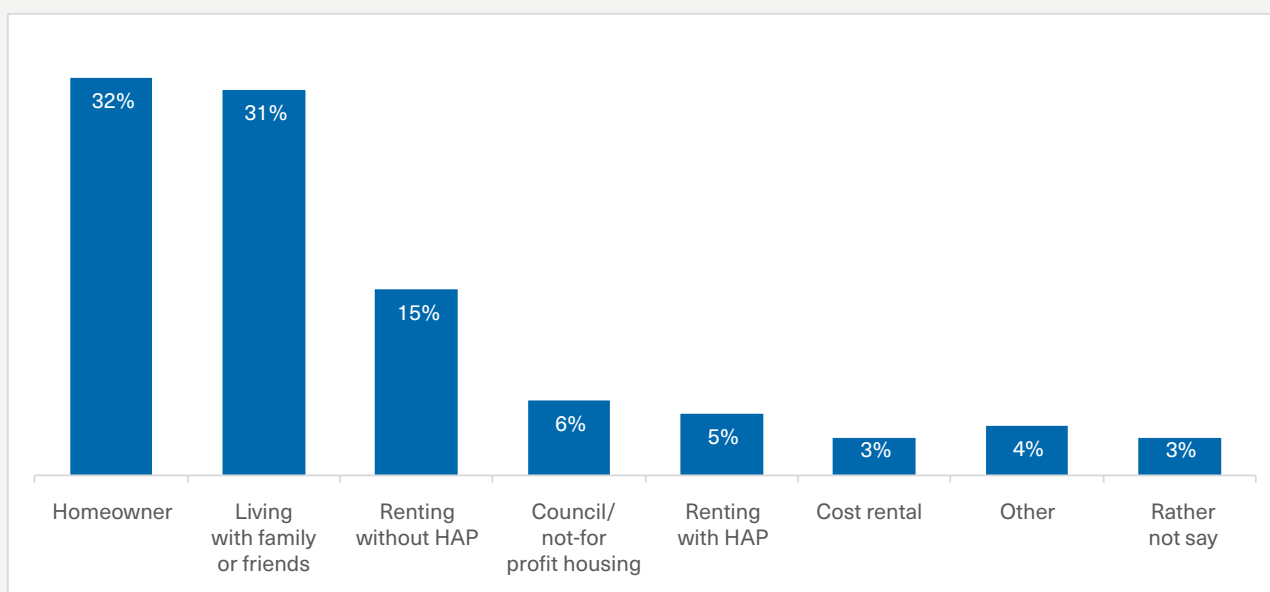
Outside the rental market

In a separate part of the survey, we asked a series of questions to adults in ROI living with their parents (n=397), some of whom had previously lived in the private rental sector (n=185). While this is a relatively small sample, some figures are still worth remarking upon, such as, for example, the fact that expectations for homeownership were not too dissimilar among those living at home (32% within the next five years) as compared with those still in the private rental sector (35%).

This challenges the convention of a linear housing pathway, whereby individuals move sequentially from the parental home to private rental accommodation to their own home. Instead, we observe a strategic response to housing unaffordability and the effect of high rents on the aspiration of homeownership, with many perhaps lower-income renters returning to the family home. The fact that these renters do not have diminished expectations suggests, in some respect, that this is a particularly viable strategy.

Indeed, those living at home are about half as likely as current renters to expect to be renting with HAP or without HAP. Instead, they are more likely to anticipate still living with family. This aligns with the idea that many people outside the private rental market hope to bypass the private rental sector altogether on their path to homeownership or use it as an interim step to finding a more permanent housing situation.

Figure 5. Expectations of respondents living at home with their parents/rent free – ‘In what type of accommodation do you EXPECT to be living in, in five years’ time?’ (Sample size n = 185)



Qualitative research on preferences & expectations

Interviews with renters reflected the survey findings on preferences and expectations. While owning one's own home remains the goal for most renters, it feels increasingly out of reach. Patrice describes how rising property prices have forced her to rent for far longer than she ever anticipated:

"I'm not renting by choice – I'm trying to get a deposit for a house. It feels like they keep moving the goalposts. You save your 10%, but then house prices go up, so the 10% keeps getting bigger. I've been renting since I was 23 and I'm now 42. It's like you're trying to climb a ladder all the time, but you don't know where the top is."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Lyn also aspires to own her own home but sees her age and depleting savings as major barriers:

"We had to eat into the capital we'd set aside to buy a home – just to live, to pay rent, to buy a car, because public transport wasn't great where we were. Then rents were horrendous, so we couldn't save to get back on track. Now we're at an age where no one will give us a mortgage."

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

She foresees a difficult future in retirement:

"We'd have a small pension and the state pension, but we wouldn't be able to afford rent. The prospect of being homeless is huge."

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

Some renters see social housing as their preferred long-term option, but, nevertheless, expect to remain in the private rental sector, referencing constrained supply as a barrier to entry:

"I suppose my option would be social housing through Dublin City Council, but I wouldn't be holding my breath anytime soon. When it comes to renting, I feel like I have no security, each year my rent goes up, but my income stays the same. I just got a letter last week saying my rent will go up again in December. I'd have more security in social housing. They talk about these rent pressure zones, but I don't really get it, because my rent keeps rising every single year."

— Barry, Republic of Ireland

Few renters interviewed in the Republic were aware of cost-rental schemes, and among those who were, limited supply and high prices were key deterrents:

"There was one advertised independently that I applied for, but I never heard anything. And we also applied for a council one, still nothing."

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

"If I moved to a cost rental place, it would actually be more expensive than where I live now. I thought it would be more like a council rent, around 33% of your income, but it would be about 50% of mine or my husband's wages. I pay €1,350 for a two-bed, and I'd pay that for a one-bed under cost rental."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

In NI, the majority of renters also rent out of necessity rather than choice, yet a higher proportion of NI renters would describe renting as a conscious or acceptable preference. In interviews, some NI renters explained how they valued the flexibility and reduced responsibility that renting offers:

"It gives you that much more flexibility if you wanted to move location or anything."

— Oliver, Northern Ireland

"There's someone else who can come in and fix stuff, or should be coming in to fix stuff."

— Edel, Northern Ireland

While the differences between the two jurisdictions were modest, survey respondents in NI were marginally less likely to express a preference for owning their own home and marginally more likely to express a preference for social housing. This attitude was also reflected in interviews:

"Owning a house, to me, was never something I desired to do. I've never desired to own something. The only thing I want is security."

— Stephen, Northern Ireland

Preferences for intermediate housing options, such as intermediate rent or cost-rental, were more limited. In ROI, just 4% preferred cost-rental while 5% expected it.

Security of Tenure

Across the island of Ireland, many respondents experience uncertainty about their housing situation. Rising rents, short leases and inconsistent housing standards may make it more difficult to feel secure or to plan for the future. This ‘housing precarity’ describes the situation many people find themselves in where they have a place to live but remain vulnerable to changes that could disrupt their lives or well-being (Waldron, 2022).⁹ Byrne and McArdle (2022)¹⁰ found that even with new tenant protections, such as rent caps and extended notice periods, many renters still encounter landlords who ignore regulations or fail to maintain their properties. As a result, tenants frequently feel they have little control over their homes or living circumstances. Byrne and McArdle’s research shows that housing precarity stems not only from high rents but also from the limited control renters have over the condition and security of their homes.

Time spent renting

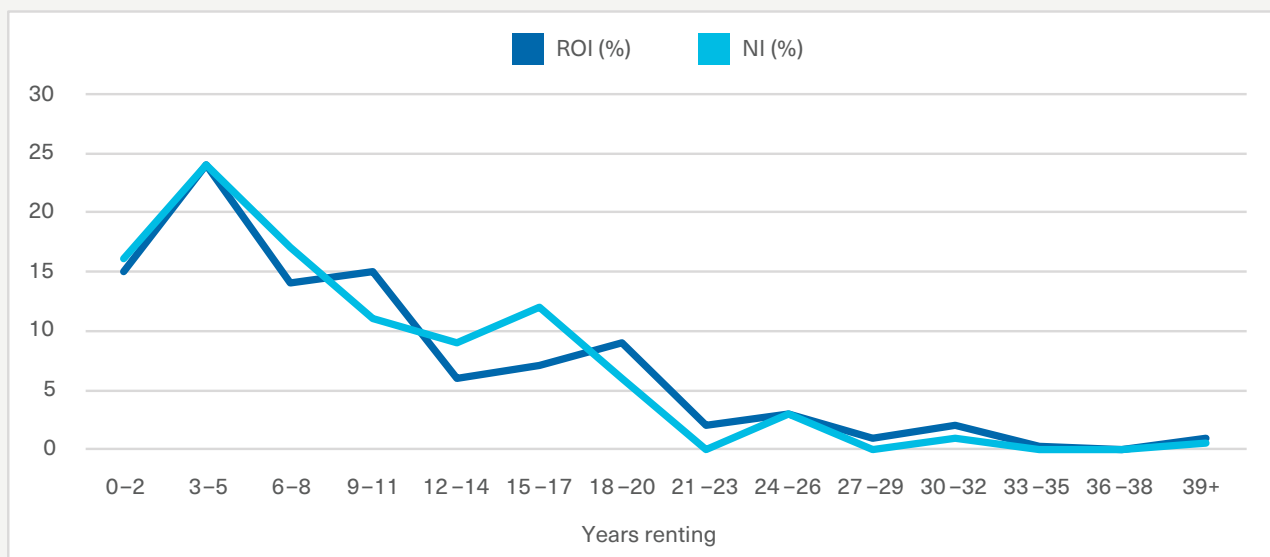
Throughout both jurisdictions, a sustained engagement with the rental market was observed. Island-wide, 61% report renting for six years or more, with this figure nearly identical between NI and ROI. The largest group of renters, comprising one quarter of all renters, have rented for 3-5 years. We estimate that tenants in ROI have been renting for an average of 9.8 years, compared with 9.1 years in NI. This is marginally larger than the figure of eight years calculated by the Housing Agency in 2023.¹¹ That survey had a smaller sample size of 373 renters, compared to our larger, more representative sample (n=1,380). Perhaps further stagnation in the rental sector has affected this average since 2023, leading it to increase. Nevertheless, the difference between ROI and NI in time spent renting is much narrower than we might have assumed, given that the housing crisis has been a long-standing issue in ROI.

⁹ Waldron, R. (2022). Experiencing housing precarity in the private rental sector during the covid-19 pandemic: the case of Ireland. *Housing Studies*, 38(1), 84-106.

¹⁰ McArdle, R., and Byrne, M. (2022). Rootlessness: How the Irish private rental sector prevents tenants feeling secure in their homes and tenant’s resistance against this. *Geoforum*, 136, 211-218.

¹¹ The Housing Agency. (2023). Residential satisfaction in Ireland 2023 (National Study of Housing Experiences, Attitudes and Aspirations in Ireland).

Figure 6. Time spent renting in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – 'How many years have you been renting?'



Things become clearer when we examine the relationship with income. In NI, there is an inverse relationship between income and longevity in the rental sector: higher earners tend to spend less time renting. This is a pattern we might expect, exiting the housing market to purchase a house.

By contrast, those on the highest incomes in ROI have spent the most time in the rental market, with those earning over €80,000 having rented for an average of 12.2 years. This is the longest duration across all income categories, with 74% of this high-income group expressing aspirations to own their own home in five years' time. This reflects a different pattern in ROI, where many people on higher incomes aspire to own a home but remain in the private rental sector for a longer time, while those on lower incomes are perhaps exiting the rental market in larger numbers to return to their family home or indeed emigrate. A major difference between the two jurisdictions is the average rent. Advertised new 2-bed apartments in the Republic of Ireland are estimated to be €2,080 (Daft.ie)¹² as compared with the £975 (equivalent to €1,125)¹³ for the equivalent in Northern Ireland. While median incomes in ROI are higher, the rent is much less affordable in the Republic of Ireland compared to Northern Ireland¹⁴.

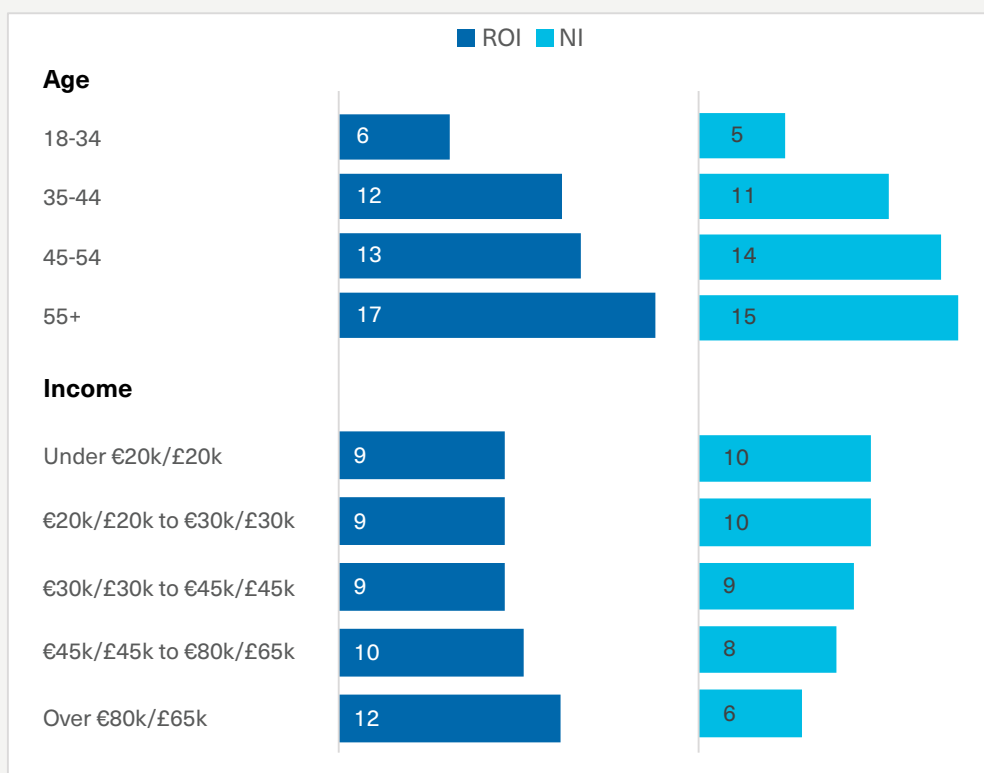
We estimate the income difference in ROI between a current renter and a renter who has returned to the family home to be just over €9,000 per annum. As so many have left the private rental sector to return to their family home, this invariably has a compositional effect in terms of the type of person who remains in the private rental sector in ROI.

¹² <https://www.thejournal.ie/daft-ie-renting-report-6870778-Nov2025/>

¹³ Author calculation via PropertyPal.com

¹⁴ The affordability ratio of rent (of a two bed apartment) to income (median monthly income of full-time employees) in NI is 0.32% compared with approximately 0.66 in ROI

Figure 7. Average number of years spent in the private rental sector broken down by age and income in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘How many years have you been renting?’



Churn in the rental market

The rate at which people move from one property to the next is considered the churn in the rental market. The Housing Agency’s 2023 Residential Satisfaction report showed that 56% of ROI renters were likely or very likely to move within the next five years, compared with 26% of the overall population. This raises further questions about the frequency with which renters move from one property to another.

Our research shows there is a large group of renters in ROI who have rented a high number of properties. One in four renters in ROI have rented six or more properties, compared with one in ten in NI. Also, in ROI, 10% of renters have lived in 10 or more properties, compared with only 3% in NI.

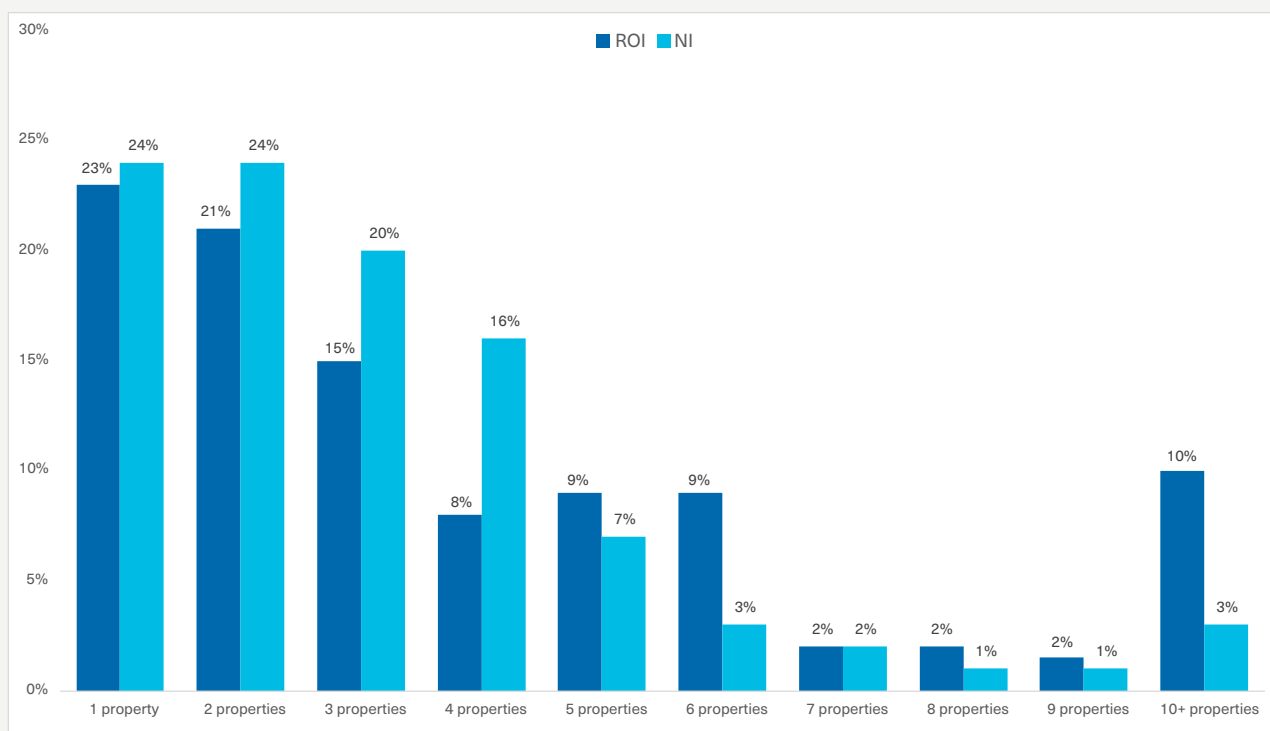
We also estimate that the average number of properties lived in is approximately four properties in ROI and three in NI.¹⁵ We can further estimate that the average number of years lived per property is 3.1 years in ROI compared with 4 years in NI.

¹⁵ This is based on the assumption that all of those who rented 10+ properties rented 10 properties yielding 3.8 in ROI and 3.1 in NI. This is almost certainly an underestimate, however. If we assume it is

This degree of churn in ROI may appear surprising in light of existing rent controls, which one may expect to yield stability and reduce residential mobility. However, the introduction of Rent Pressure Zones (RPZs) in ROI has coincided with a reduction in supply and an increase in no-fault evictions and therefore perhaps greater mobility. Indeed, the average number of years per rental property among Dublin-based respondents is significantly lower, at 2.8 years.

That said, an important caveat that must be applied to comparisons between ROI and NI concerns the larger number of people who migrate to Ireland, and Dublin in particular, from overseas or other Irish counties, where mobility is often motivated by choice and employment opportunities. For many participants in the ROI sample, the property they lived in most recently, as compared with their current one, may very well have been in another country.

Figure 8. Number of properties rented in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘How many properties have you rented over the years in the private rental sector (Including the one you are in)?’



Reasons for moving

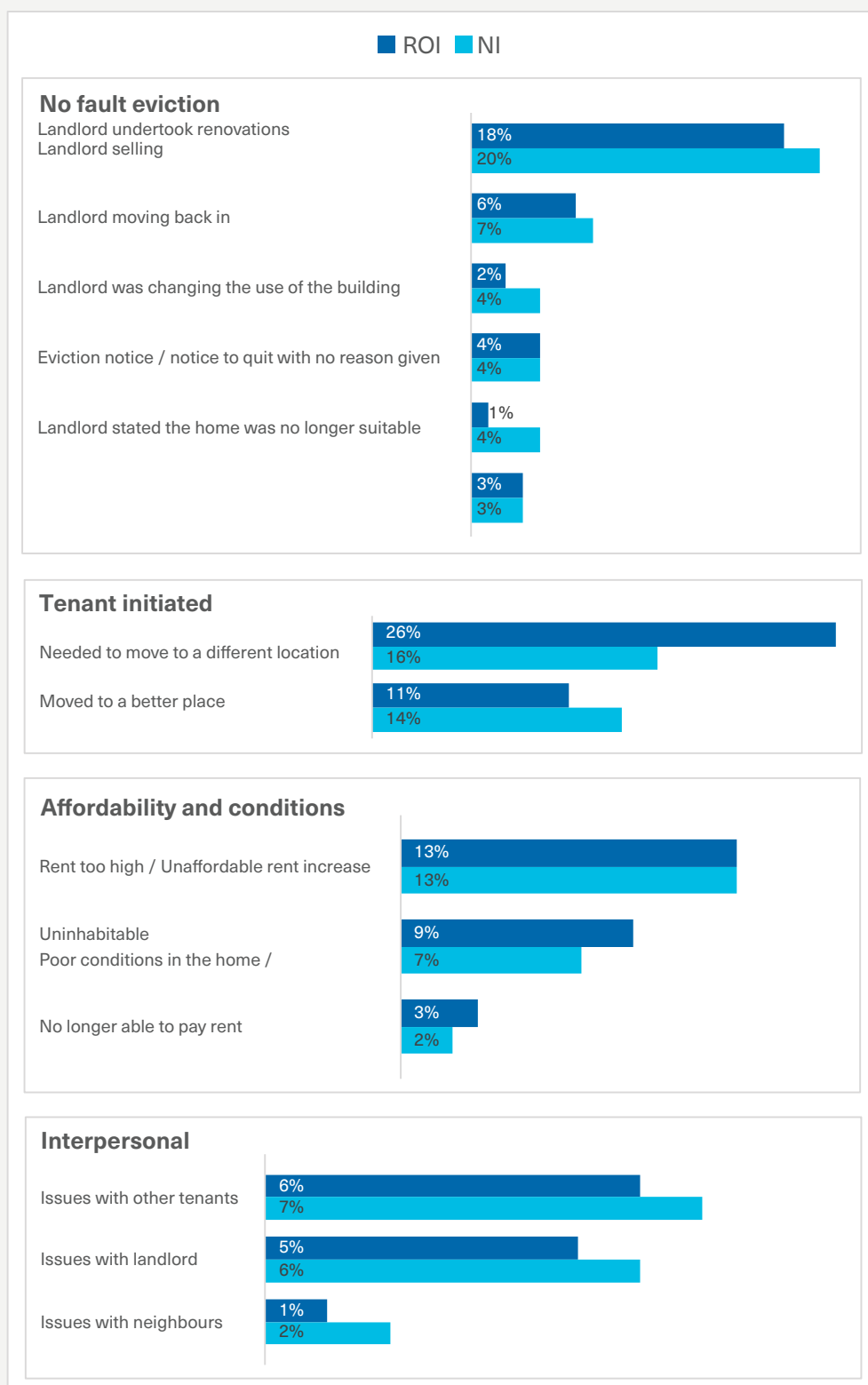
There are similarities between the two jurisdictions in the reasons given for moving. The prominence of landlords selling their property drives one in five tenant moves in both NI and ROI. Across the island, less than half of all moves are initiated by tenants.

A large group of renters, 34% in ROI and 42% in NI, moved due to reasons that would fall under the broad category of 'no-fault eviction'. This includes: 'Landlord selling'; 'Landlord moving back in'; 'Landlord undertook renovations'; 'Landlord was changing the use of the building'; 'Eviction notice with no reason given'; or 'Landlord stated the home was no longer suitable'.

Tenants in ROI are more likely to move due to a need to relocate, with 26% of respondents in ROI indicating that this was the motivation for their most recent move, as compared with 16% in NI. This perhaps reflects the aforementioned prevalence of economic migration in ROI, both external and internal, where many renters move to and from Dublin. For example, since 2020, the population of NI has grown by about 1.5%, while ROI's population has increased by 7% overall and 11% in Dublin specifically.

As respondents were allowed to select more than one reason for moving, there is some overlap in renters' responses. Of those who indicated that they moved because their rent was too high (13%), one in four of these also highlighted a no-fault eviction as an additional factor. This was not the case for those who left their last tenancy due to their need to relocate (something that is more common among younger renters), for whom just 1 in 14 reported a no-fault eviction.

Figure 9. Reasons for respondents leaving previous rental homes in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘Why did you leave your last rental home?’ [Select all that apply]



Outside the rental market

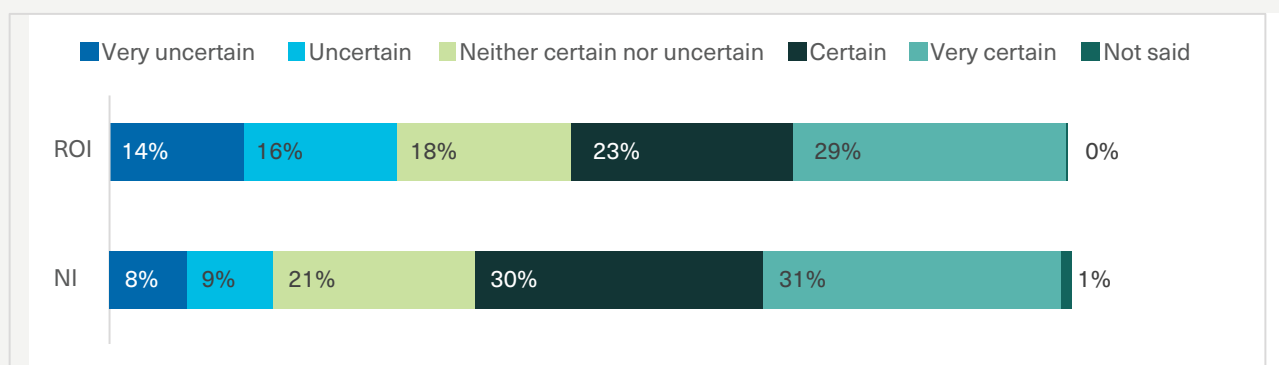
This data contrasts with the experiences of people in ROI who previously rented but are now living with their parents. The data suggests that they have been priced out of the rental market. While just 13% of current renters indicate that they last moved due to high or unaffordable rents, 52% of those living at home indicated that they moved back home due to high or unaffordable rents, which is four times the rate among current renters. Likewise, 10% cite being unable to pay their rent, which is over three times the incidence reported by those still renting.

Perceived uncertainty

Renting in the private rental sector involves higher levels of uncertainty compared to other housing tenures. Some aspects of this are driven by tenants: the Housing Agency's Residential Satisfaction Survey (2024) found that 19% of those renting in ROI were doing so because they were unsure where they would eventually settle down. However, much uncertainty also comes from the sector's precarity, which presents problems that are beyond the tenant's control. Threshold's Generation Rent survey (2024) highlighted that most renters feel either very insecure or insecure in their tenancy. In our survey, we asked respondents how certain they felt about their circumstances one year into the future.

Across the island, a slim majority of 54% of renters report that they feel either very certain or certain that they will be living in the same accommodation in a year's time. Just over a quarter (27%) of renters feel either uncertain or very uncertain about the status of their current tenancy over the next year, and 19% feeling neither certain nor uncertain.

Figure 10. Perceived uncertainty in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – 'How certain do you feel that you will be living in the same accommodation in 1 year's time?'



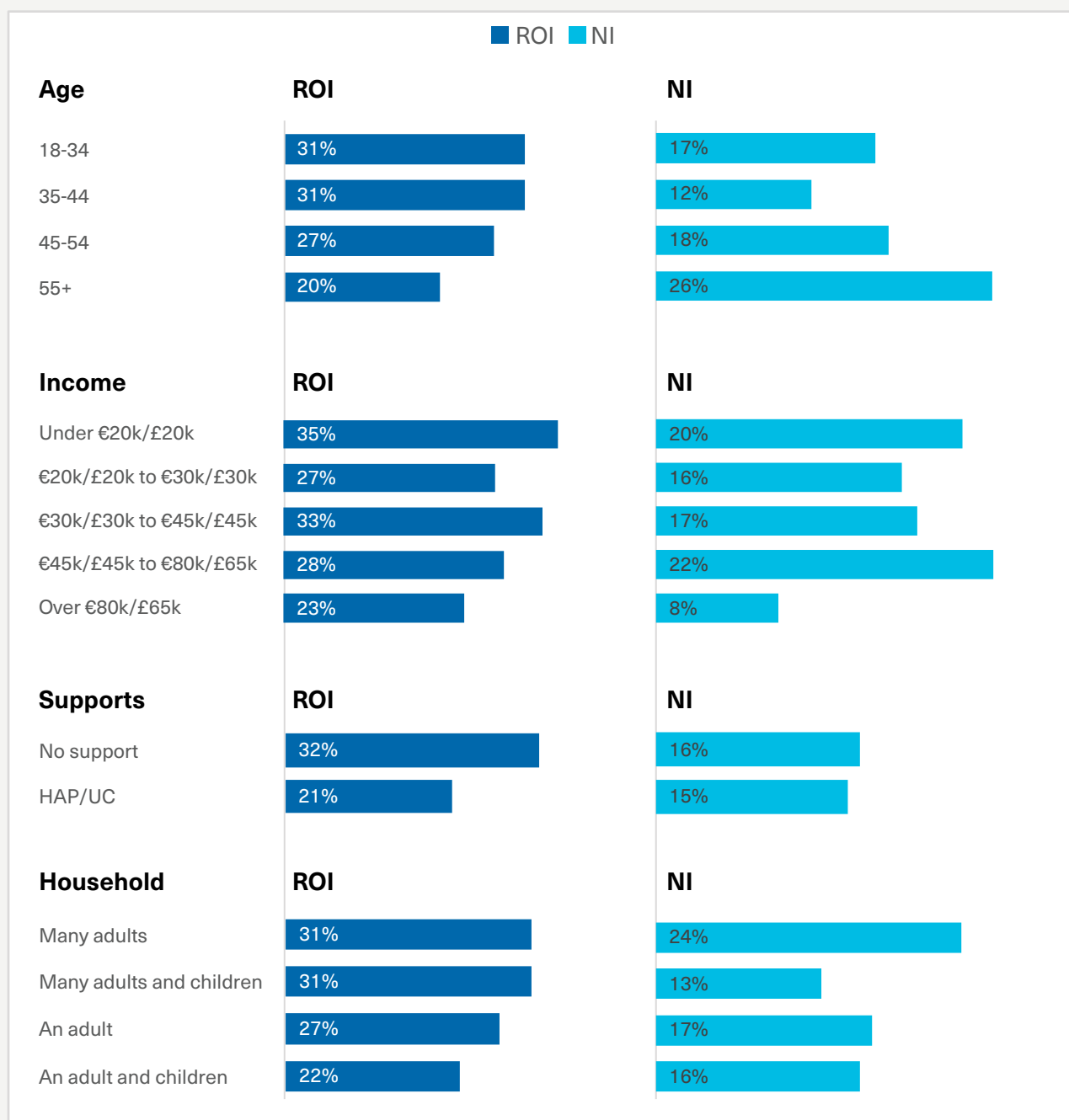
Overall, renters are more uncertain in ROI when compared with NI. In ROI, 30% of renters report feeling either uncertain or very uncertain about remaining in their current accommodation, compared with 17% in NI. Within ROI, regional disparities in reported uncertainty are minimal. Within NI, the high levels of uncertainty are seen in eastern counties, including Antrim, Down and Armagh, where 21% of renters report feeling uncertain or very uncertain.

Across both jurisdictions, the level of uncertainty varies by demographic group. In ROI, renters under 45 are the most uncertain, with 31% being either uncertain or very uncertain. Those without financial supports, such as HAP, are also more uncertain in ROI. This may be because, once a tenant is approved for HAP, additional requirements are placed on the landlord, which may lead to greater housing stability. In NI, older tenants are the most uncertain, with 26% of those aged 55 and over being either uncertain or very uncertain.

Those with very high incomes report feeling more secure than lower earners. Over a third (35%) of individuals earning less than €20,000 annually report feeling uncertain or very uncertain about whether they will still be living in their current accommodation in a year's time. This decreases markedly for those on the highest incomes in both ROI and NI, dropping to 8% for those earning over £65,000 in NI. This confirms previous observations – those on the highest incomes in NI appear to feel more secure in their accommodation than their counterparts in ROI.

Both jurisdictions see some of the highest levels of uncertainty among those living in multiple adult homes with no children, with 31% of this particular cohort in ROI and 24% in NI reporting some level of uncertainty.

Figure 11. Perceived uncertainty broken down by demographic group in Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘How certain do you feel that you will be living in the same accommodation in 1 year’s time?’



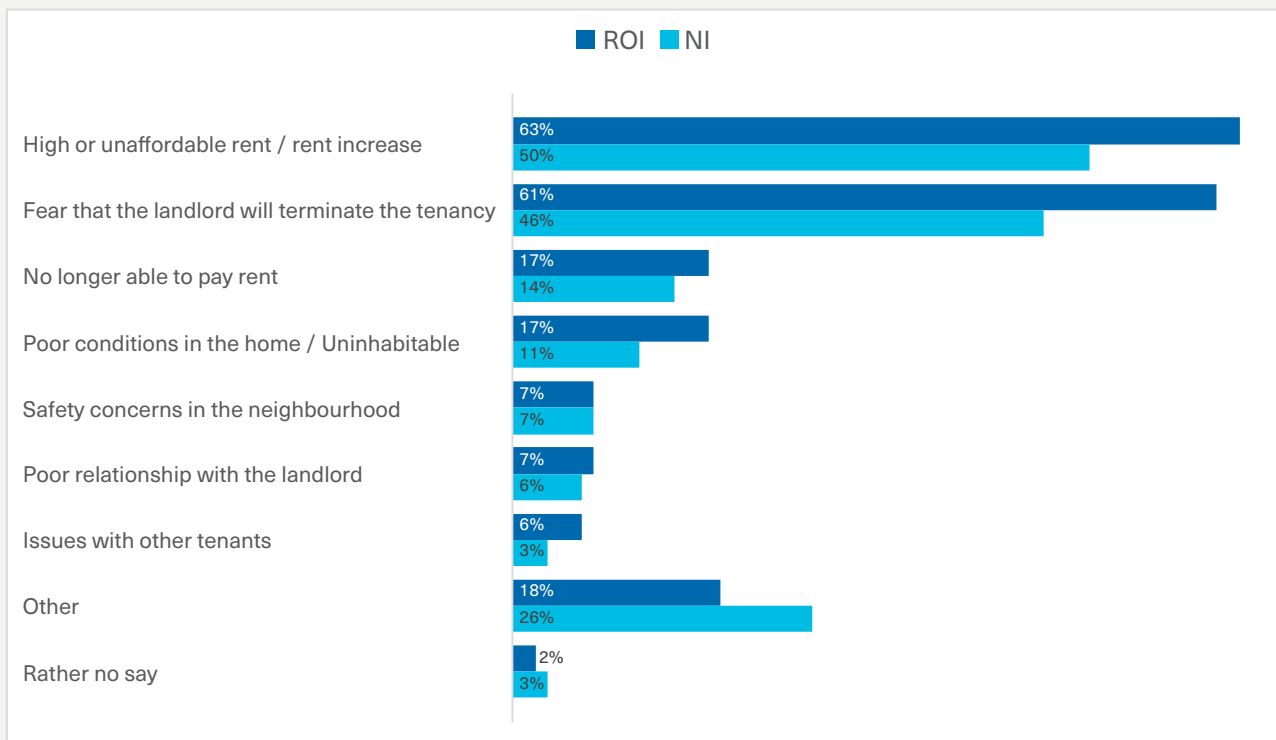
Sources of uncertainty

To analyse the causes of uncertainty, we first identified those who were uncertain and then investigated the source of their uncertainty. Renters who expressed some level of uncertainty (those who were 'uncertain', 'very uncertain' or 'neither certain nor uncertain') were asked what factors contributed to those feelings of uncertainty.

Across the island, there are two main drivers of uncertainty in the rental sector: unaffordable rent and the fear that the landlord will terminate the tenancy. What is notable is that rent increases are even more worrying in ROI, despite the national RPZ rules limiting increases to a maximum of either 2% per year or the rate of general inflation. Unaffordable rent was a factor influencing uncertainty for 63% of renters in ROI and 50% in NI. As we will see later, the overall financial pressure of rent on incomes is more prevalent in ROI than in NI.

Regarding the fear that a landlord might end their tenancy, 61% in ROI cite this as a contributing factor compared with 46% in NI. This is remarkable considering that, as of 2025, a landlord in NI has greater legal scope to end a tenancy without giving a reason. Across the island, the next most common factors are: being no longer able to pay rent (16%), living in a home that is in poor condition or uninhabitable (15%); safety concerns in the neighbourhood (7%); having a poor relationship with the landlord (7% overall); and issues with other tenants (5% overall). Renters in ROI are more likely to select these additional reasons, causing uncertainty, reflecting again that deeper underlying levels of uncertainty in ROI, as we also saw in Figure 10. In spite of the fact that renters in ROI have more protections, owing to recent legislation, they retain greater levels of uncertainty. Fears of high rents and evictions loom more prominently in the minds of renters in ROI.

Figure 12. Factors affecting perceived uncertainty in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘What factors contribute to your feelings of uncertainty regarding your current housing situation? (Select all that apply)’



In both jurisdictions, older renters are more likely to report concern that their landlord may end their tenancy, with 73% of those aged 55 or over in ROI and 70% in NI citing this reason. The difference between ROI and NI is most pronounced among younger renters: 61% of under-35s in ROI are concerned by this issue compared with just 23% in NI. This reflects a pattern of precarity for older tenants in NI.

One-parent households in ROI emerge as a group most affected by a range of uncertainties: 77% of this group identify affordability as a concern, and around two-thirds (66%) express fears that their landlord might terminate their tenancy. They are by far the most likely group to report poor or uninhabitable living conditions, with 36% citing this, far exceeding any other demographic group. In ROI, 24% of single-parent households also cited difficulties keeping up with rental payments as a source of uncertainty; the sample size in NI is too limited to analyse in this case.

Qualitative research on security of tenure

This reported uncertainty among older renters may reflect the impact of having a relatively stagnant income compared with younger age groups, where a larger proportion are still in employment. Among those approaching retirement, stagnant income remains a concern:

“We would have a small pension that we’ve managed to save up, but really small, and we would have the government pensions, so we wouldn’t be able to rent because we wouldn’t be able to afford it. So the prospect of being homeless is huge.”

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

Uncertainty among older renters is particularly concerning when Census data is considered. Data in ROI suggests that this could exacerbate. Between 2016 and 2022 (CSO 2023¹⁶) there was an 83% increase in people aged 65 or over living in private rental properties as their primary residence, which confirms that the number of older renters is rising rapidly. Older renters can face insecurities for various reasons, such as when their income becomes more stagnant or their health or mobility worsens. According to Threshold and ALONE’s Double Deficit report, the private rental sector is increasingly inadequate for meeting the housing and support needs of older renters. Our findings reflect this, but also further explore the dynamics of uncertainty within this group in ROI. In ROI, a tenancy lasting for 6 months or more can only be lawfully terminated by a landlord (provided the tenant has met their obligations) if they wish to sell the property or reclaim it for personal use or other limited grounds. These reasons emerge in interviews as reasons for past tenancy terminations. Although their relationships with their landlords are often cordial, renters are aware that tenancies frequently end with little forewarning.

In NI, interviewees’ tenancy insecurities often stem not from formal eviction processes, but from the prevalence of rolling month-to-month contracts that continue indefinitely after a fixed-term tenancy expires. If a new lease is not signed, these tenancies convert into periodic tenancies, which, while subject to the same statutory protections under the Private Tenancies Order 2006,¹⁷ offer less security of tenure compared to ROI. In NI, landlords can serve a notice to quit on a periodic tenancy without giving a reason, with the required notice period determined by the length of the tenancy. In practice, many NI renters feel uncertain, describing their housing situation as being “on the one-month whim” of their landlord. Many of the interviewees emphasised that, while affordability pressures are acute, security of tenure mattered even more:

¹⁶ <https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-cpp2/censusofpopulation2022profile2-housinginireland/backgroundnotes/>

¹⁷ Housing Rights. (2020, September 26). Eviction in Northern Ireland: Proper process and involvement of authorities. Housing Rights

"I don't mind paying if I know I'm secure. Give me a 10-year lease where rent changes are set out over time."

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

Interviews were able to delve into how one-parent households were exposed to a myriad of forces that undermined their security:

"When my son was two and I was pregnant, my landlord was selling the house, so we had to leave... that was quite difficult. Being a single, pregnant mother with a toddler, I wasn't getting a look-in anywhere."

— Triona, Republic of Ireland

Triona's experience also underlines a work-welfare trap, which can be created by childcare costs and how housing supports taper as earnings rise:

"I'm highly educated, yet it feels unattainable at the moment. When you go back to work, your other funding goes down, and childcare isn't factored in. Friends in similar situations saw their HAP go up and, once you add petrol and childcare, it actually costs to go back to work, you're trying to build a career but end up worse off."

— Triona, Republic of Ireland

Our findings are consistent with previous studies on the outlook and experiences of single parents who are renters. Findings from the CSO Pulse Survey show that single-parent renters are most likely to feel under financial pressure.¹⁸ They are also the least likely to have access to suitable childcare or to have 'practical help' to hand if they need it. They were also among the most vulnerable to energy costs, with 41% reporting a medium-to-high level of energy precarity between 2020 and 2022. In the same study, the proportion of couples with children who experienced energy precarity was a much lower 9%.

¹⁸ Central Statistics Office. (2021, July 7). Pulse Survey – Life at Home 2021: Renters, lone parents and adults living alone or with a parent: Respondents who are lone parents. Central Statistics Office.

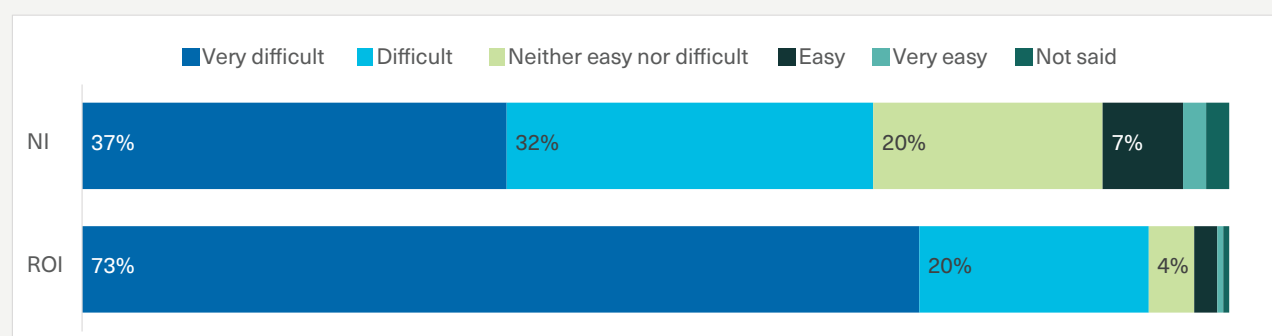
Access to the Rental Market

Across the island of Ireland, many private renters experience a sense of “rootlessness”, or an uncertainty about how long they can expect to stay in one locale or how much their rent might rise (Byrne and McArdle, 2022)¹⁹. In Northern Ireland, the statutory framework for tenancy security is “very light”, leaving much to common law and freedom of contract (Chartered Institute of Housing, 2021)²⁰. These patterns reflect a broader international trend around housing stability. Howard, Hochstenbach and Ronald show that housing stability depends less on whether someone rents or owns, and more on how secure, affordable and supported their home is in practice (Howard, Hochstenbach and Ronald, 2024).²¹ As such, the extent to which laws, welfare systems and housing policies help people sustain their tenancies and manage financial or personal pressures is vital to housing stability.

Difficulty securing accommodation

When renters across the Island were asked about their experience of finding accommodation, 64% described it as very difficult and a further 23% as difficult. Only 8% were neutral (neither easy nor difficult), while just 3% and 1% responded that it was easy or very easy, respectively, to find rental accommodation.

Figure 13. Difficulty finding rental accommodation in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘In your experience, how easy or difficult is it to find rental accommodation in [Republic of Ireland/Northern Ireland]’



¹⁹ McArdle, R., & Byrne, M. (2022). Rootlessness: How the Irish private rental sector prevents tenants feeling secure in their homes and tenant’s resistance against this. *Geoforum*, 136, 211-218.

²⁰ Perry, J., Wilson, H., Lister, S. and Cartwright, J. (2021) Private rented tenancies in Northern Ireland and ‘notice to quit’ periods. Research report commissioned by the Department for Communities (DfC). Chartered Institute of Housing (CIH), November 2021. Available at: <https://www.cih.org/media/kdkch00v/private-rented-tenancies-ntq-report-ni-final.pdf>

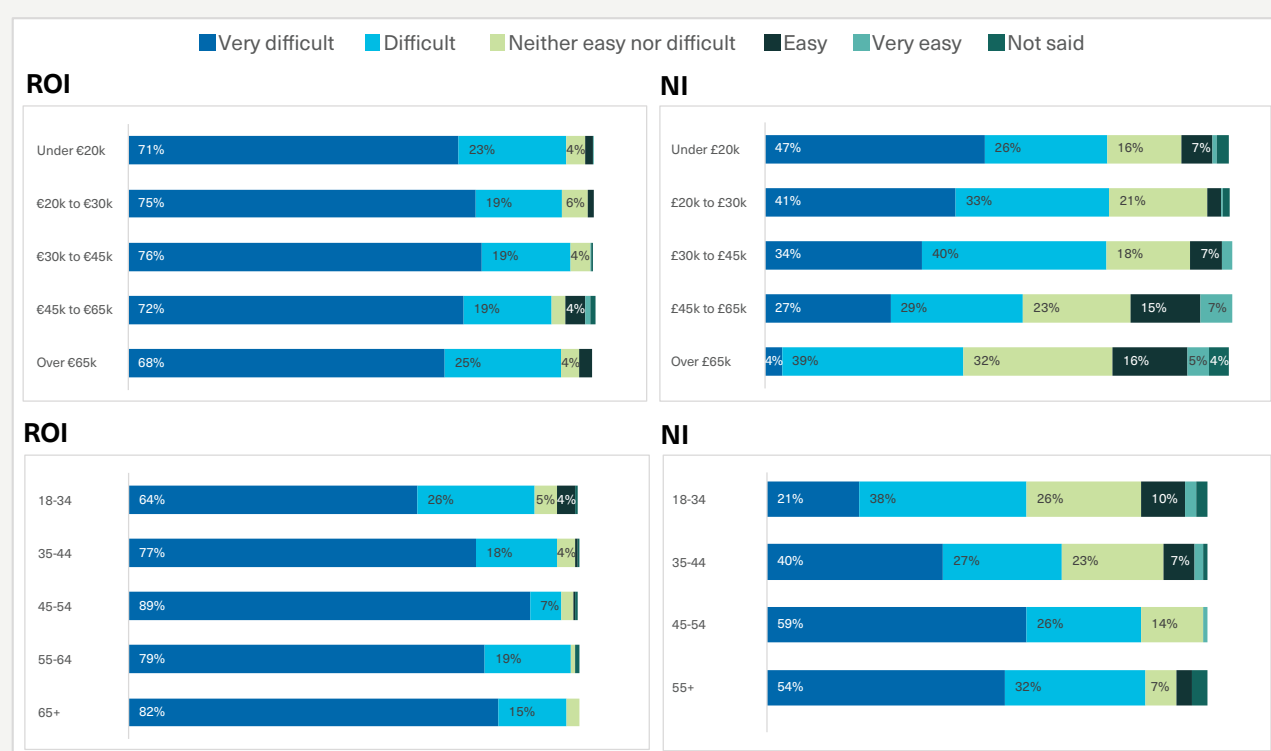
²¹ Howard, A., Hochstenbach, C., & Ronald, R. (2024). Understanding generational housing inequalities beyond tenure, class and context. *Economy and Society*, 53(1), 135-162.

This picture is stark in ROI, where 93% of renters consider the search for accommodation as either difficult or very difficult. Strikingly, this trend is relatively even across socioeconomic groups in ROI. Across income levels, the majority of renters find securing accommodation very difficult: 71% of respondents earning under €20,000 and 68% of those earning over €80,000 find it very difficult.

In NI, the experience of finding rental accommodation is also challenging, though to a lesser extent than ROI. There are also big differences between renters on lower and higher incomes. Those on the highest incomes, in NI, report very little difficulty. Just 4% indicate that it was very difficult to find accommodation, as compared with 68% of the highest incomes in ROI.

According to our data, younger renters in NI have comparatively less difficulty accessing rented accommodation, possibly reflecting the greater flexibility younger people have in where they can live before settling down, with options of living in shared housing. At the same time, older age groups in NI seem to face more difficulty finding rental accommodation, perhaps due to the relative scarcity of long-term family accommodation in the jurisdiction.

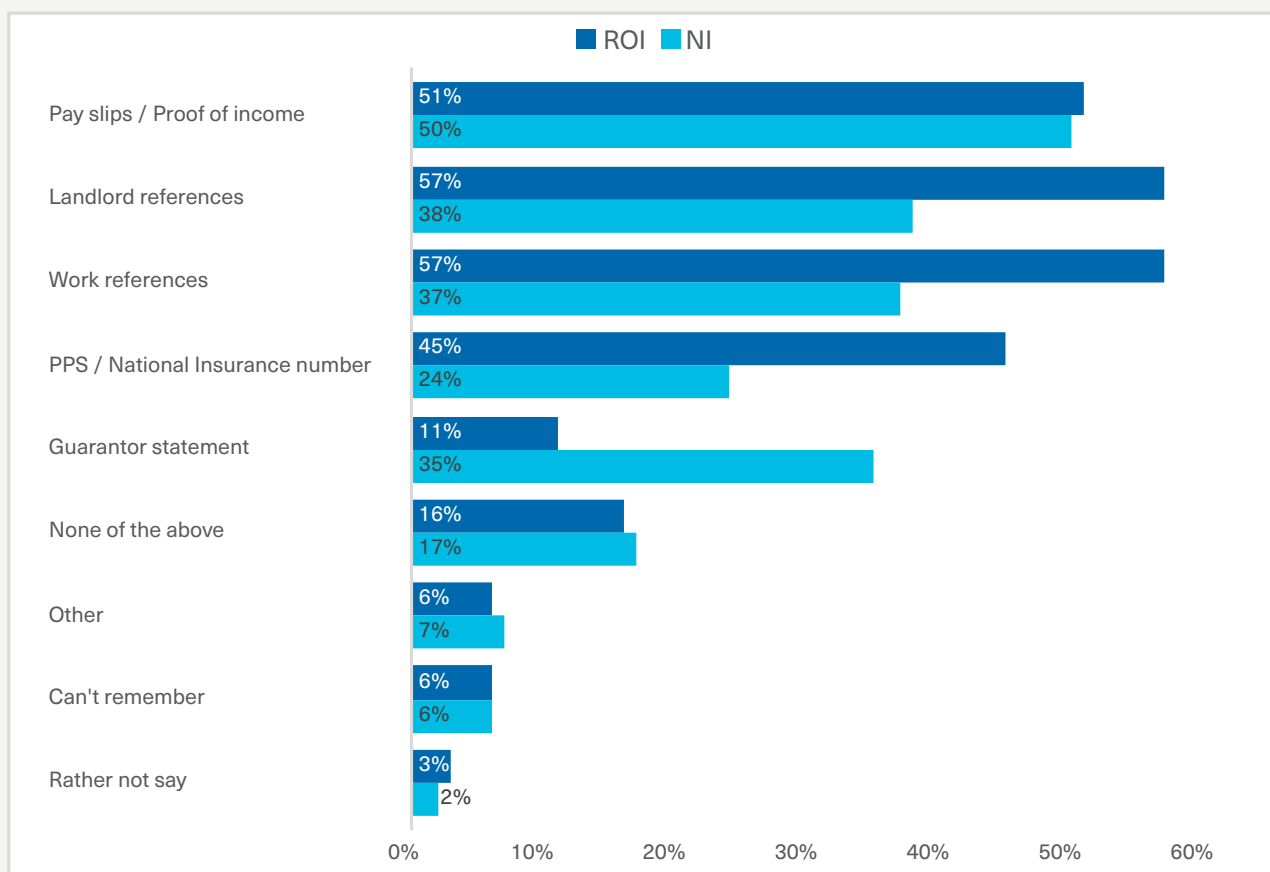
Figure 14. Relationship between difficulty in securing a tenancy and demography (income and age group) in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – 'In your experience, how easy or difficult is it to find rental accommodation in [Republic of Ireland/ Northern Ireland]'



Documentation necessary to secure housing

When asked about the documentation they needed to provide before viewing a property, clear differences emerge between renters in each jurisdiction. In ROI, renters are more likely to need to supply references to prospective landlords, with 57% providing landlord references and 57% supplying work references; additionally, 51% provided payslips or proof of income, and 45% provided their PPS number. Similar to ROI, half of renters in NI reported having to provide payslips or proof of income. However, fewer NI renters report having to provide landlord references (38%), work references (37%) or their national insurance number (24%) to prospective landlords. The more onerous requirements in ROI reflect the market conditions and the difficulties faced by tenants there. Taken together, just 16% of renters in ROI and 15% in NI did not have to provide any documentation to prospective landlords. This figure is larger in rural areas of ROI, perhaps reflecting a slightly less formal rental market in less populated areas.

Figure 15. Documents required by prospective landlords from tenants in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘Which of the following did you have to provide to the landlord before viewing the property? [Select all that apply]’



Overall, the most significant difference between NI and ROI lies in the reliance on guarantor statements, with 35% of renters in NI providing a guarantor statement, compared to only 11% in ROI. The demographic group most likely to be asked for guarantor statements in NI is 18-to 34-year-olds (44%), which may create an additional barrier to finding rental accommodation for those without strong family financial backing. In ROI, the focus on references could potentially pose a challenge to those without stable employment or rental histories. Thus, one could therefore argue that the high bar for information reinforces preexisting social inequalities.

In interviews, renters described being discouraged by the “*very, very competitive*” nature of the rental market, where often “*you don’t even get through the door*” for a viewing. Many reported needing to take whatever accommodation become available, even if it did not meet their household’s needs, reflecting constrained choices: “*I had to take a house two or three times bigger than I need because there’s nowhere else to go*”, “*I felt like I had to take something. It’s definitely not value for money at all.*”

Outside the rental market

Our analysis also compares the experiences of those in the rental market with those of adults who live in the family home, based on ROI data only due to limited sample sizes in NI. In the literature, instances in which adults choose to move back into the familial home for extended periods due to housing unaffordability are described as ‘boomerang moves’.²²

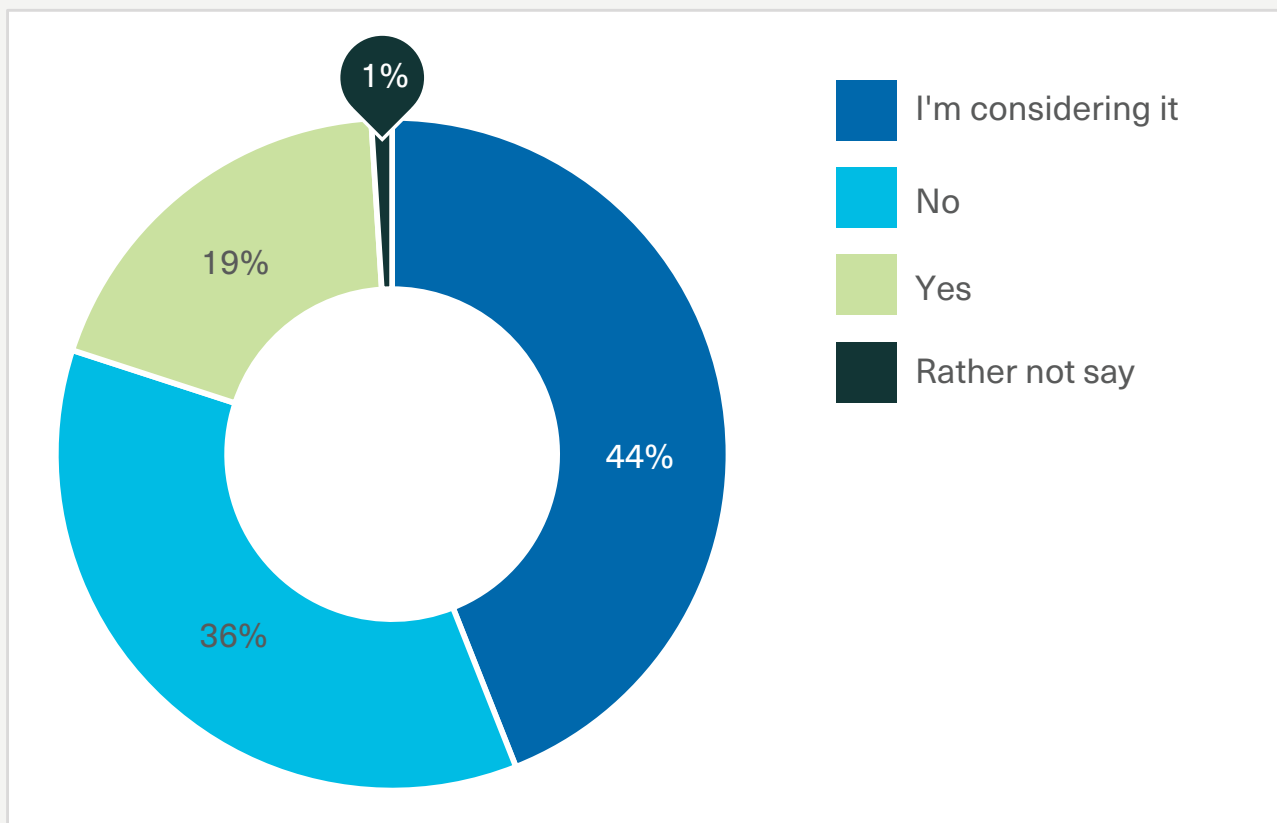
This group, who live at home with their parents, report greater precarity in the private rented sector, especially on affordability. Just over half (52%) report that they left their last tenancy as the rent was too high or unaffordable, which is a rate four times that of current renters. A further 10% cite no longer being able to pay rent as a factor. This group was less likely than the general renter population to report leaving their last rental home due to reasons classified as a no-fault eviction. Instead, their access to the rental market appears to be constrained by personal finances. This group also reported a slightly higher incidence of their security deposits being unfairly withheld by the landlord: 38% compared with 29% of current renters in ROI.

This group is also much more likely to consider emigration. Nearly two-thirds (63%) of these former renters are either considering or planning to emigrate to another country. Of those considering or planning to move to another country, 71% identified housing affordability as a major influence on their decision. In comparison, a further 26% viewed it as a minor factor, and only 3% said it was not a factor at all. As such, it seems clear that the housing crisis in ROI is causing significant numbers to consider a move abroad.. This

²² Arundel, R. and Lennartz, C. (2017) ‘Returning to the parental home: Boomerang moves of younger adults and the welfare regime context’, *Journal of European Social Policy*

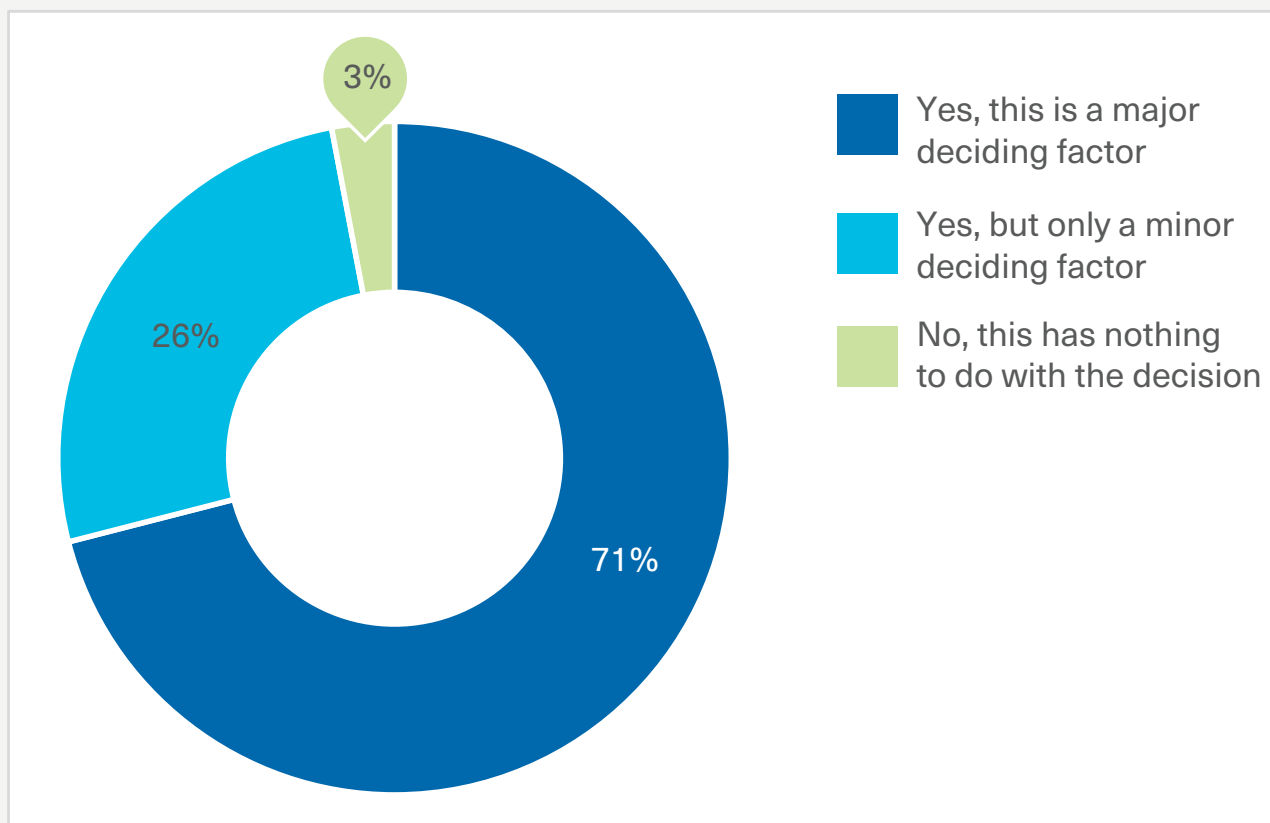
corresponds with CSO research published in 2022,²³ which explores people's opinions on the cost of living. It showed that 57% of 18-29-year-olds and 43% of those in rented accommodation were considering emigration to lower their cost of living. Indeed, CSO data shows that emigration of Irish nationals has steadily increased over the last four years, with 2025 seeing the highest number emigrating since 2016.

Figure 16. Emigration ambitions of those living at home (e.g. with parents) in the Republic of Ireland only – 'Do you plan on emigrating to another country?'



²³ Central Statistics Office. (2022, December 5). Pulse Survey: Our Lives, Our Money – Key Findings. Central Statistics Office. <https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/fp/fp-psolom/pulsesurveyourlivesourmoney-octobertonovember2022/>

Figure 17. Housing affordability for those considering emigration only, in the Republic of Ireland only – ‘Does the affordability of housing play a factor in your decision?’



Affordability & Financial Pressure

Financial pressure in housing happens when accommodation costs consistently strain household budgets, leaving limited income for essentials like food, transport and healthcare. Across Ireland, this pressure has worsened as housing costs increase faster than wages (Oireachtas Parliamentary Budget Office, 2023²⁴; Ulster University 2025²⁵). In Northern Ireland, housing remains more affordable than in 2007, but over the last 5 and 10 years, it has become significantly less affordable.

Some research (Norris and Byrne, 2020²⁶; UN Human Rights Council, 2017²⁷; McKee and Soaita, 2022²⁸) links this trend to the financialization of housing. This is where homes are treated as investment assets rather than places to live. It is argued that this shift, driven by long-term reliance on market-based provision, makes housing less affordable for low-to-middle-income homeowners, where accommodation costs outpace wage growth. A survey of private renters in NI conducted by Renters' Voice (a tenant forum supported by Housing Rights) revealed serious financial anxiety: 74% of respondents who reported being unable to cover all household expenses said they prioritised paying rent over other essentials (Housing Rights, 2023)²⁹.

²⁴ Oireachtas Parliamentary Budget Office. (2023). Housing affordability for private household buyers in Ireland (Publication 34 of 2023). Houses of the Oireachtas Service: https://data.oireachtas.ie/ie/oireachtas/parliamentaryBudgetOffice/2023/2023-10-05_housing-affordability-for-private-household-buyers-in-ireland_en.pdf

²⁵ Ulster University. (2025). Northern Ireland House Price Index reports (Q1–Q3 2025). Ulster University Research on Property and Planning - House Price Index <https://www.ulster.ac.uk/research/topic/built-environment/research-property-planning/housing-market-reports/house-price-index>

²⁶ Norris, M., and Byrne, M. (2022). Housing market financialization, neoliberalism and everyday retrenchment of social housing. *Environment and Planning A: Economy and Space*, 54(1), 182–198. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0308518X19832614>

²⁷ Farha, L. (2017). Financialization of housing and the right to adequate housing (Report No. A/HRC/34/51). United Nations Human Rights Council. <https://www.ohchr.org/en/documents/thematic-reports/ahrc3451-report-special-rapporteur-adequate-housing-component-right>

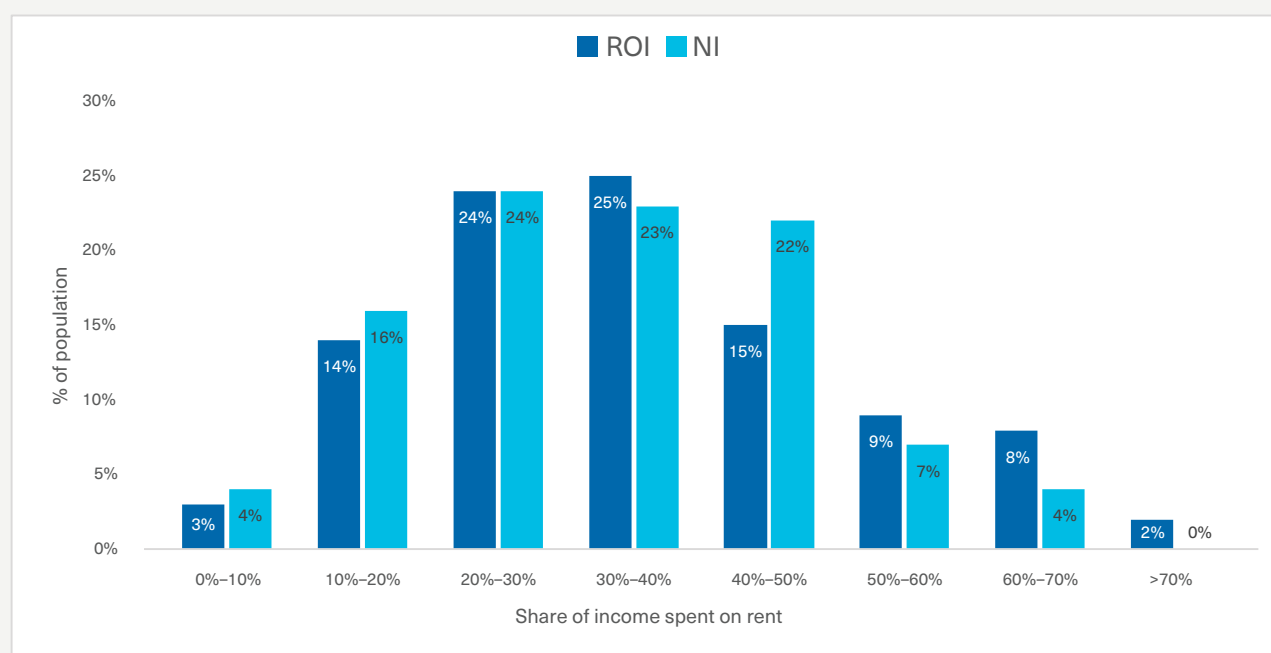
²⁸ Soaita, A. M., Simcock, T., and McKee, K. (2022). Housing challenges faced by low-income and other vulnerable privately renting households: An evidence review (Research Report). UK Collaborative Centre for Housing Evidence (CaCHE). https://housingevidence.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/2022/09/Housing_challenges_faced_by_lowincome_renters_evidence_review_Sept_2022.pdf

²⁹ Housing Rights. (2023). Cost of Living Crisis Report. Renters' Voice, February 2023. https://www.housingrights.org.uk/sites/default/files/documents/policy-research/renters-voice-cost-of-living-crisis-report-2023-final-pdf_0.pdf.

Share of income spent on rent

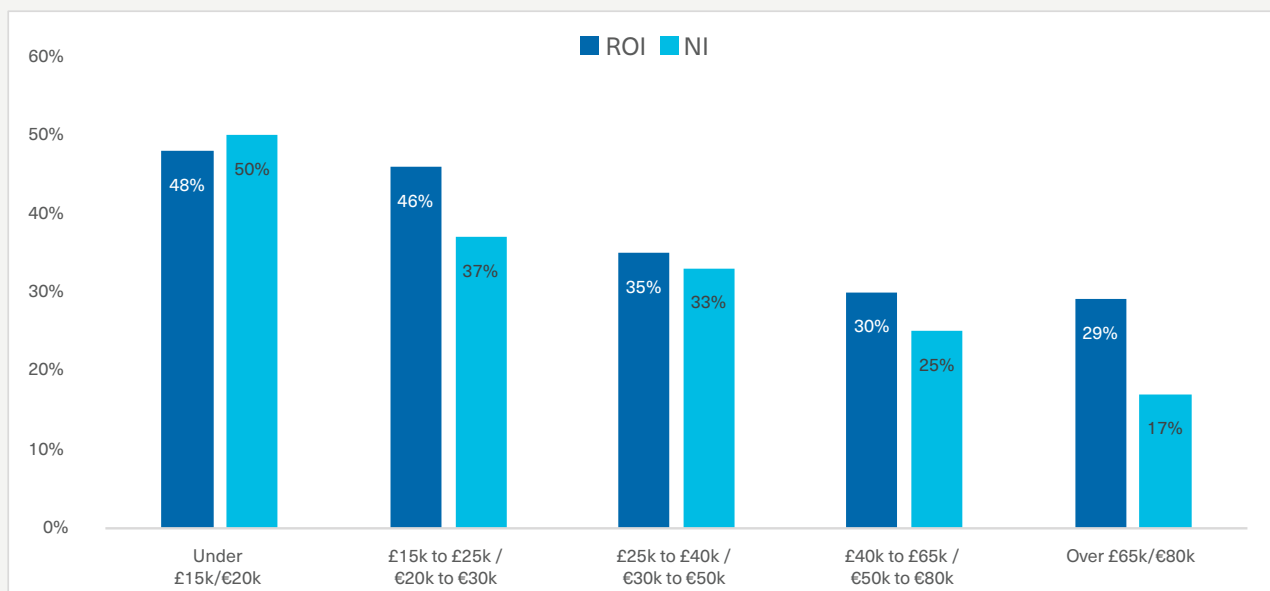
Our study aimed to estimate the proportion of income spent on rent. Renters were asked to report their monthly and annual income, the rent they paid, and the proportion of their income allocated to rent. By combining these figures, accounting for taxation regimes, and removing inconsistent responses, we calculated an estimate of the proportion of monthly income spent on rent. In ROI, an average of 37% monthly post-tax income is spent by tenants on rent. In NI, renters spend a slightly lower average of 32% of their net income on rent. This figure for NI is somewhat closer to that of ROI than would otherwise have been expected.

Figure 18. Share of net monthly income spent on rent in Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI)



The financial situation facing some renters is more pressing than that of others. In ROI, those under 25, those earning less than €20,000, and those earning between €20,000 and €30,000 spend 42%, 48% and 46% of their net income on rent, respectively. The proportion of income allocated to rent decreases as salary increases. In NI, those earning below £15,000 spend 48% of their net income on rent, which declines across higher-income groups, with those in the highest-income group spending 17% on rent. These figures do not account for benefits such as Universal Credit or Housing Benefit. Notably, the decline in the share of income spent on rent is faster among tenants in NI. Those on the higher incomes in ROI are paying a far higher share of their net income on rent.

Figure 19. Share of the income spent on rent, broken down by income group. [At the time of the survey the €/£ exchange rate was 1.2, giving us the comparable groups given below]



Ability to pay bills

According to CSO data, while just 30.6% of people in ROI live in rented or rent-free housing, this group accounts for 56.9% of those at risk of poverty and 76.0% of those living in consistent poverty.³⁰ This merited further exploration of the financial pressures facing private sector tenants around the payment of bills, such as groceries and heating.

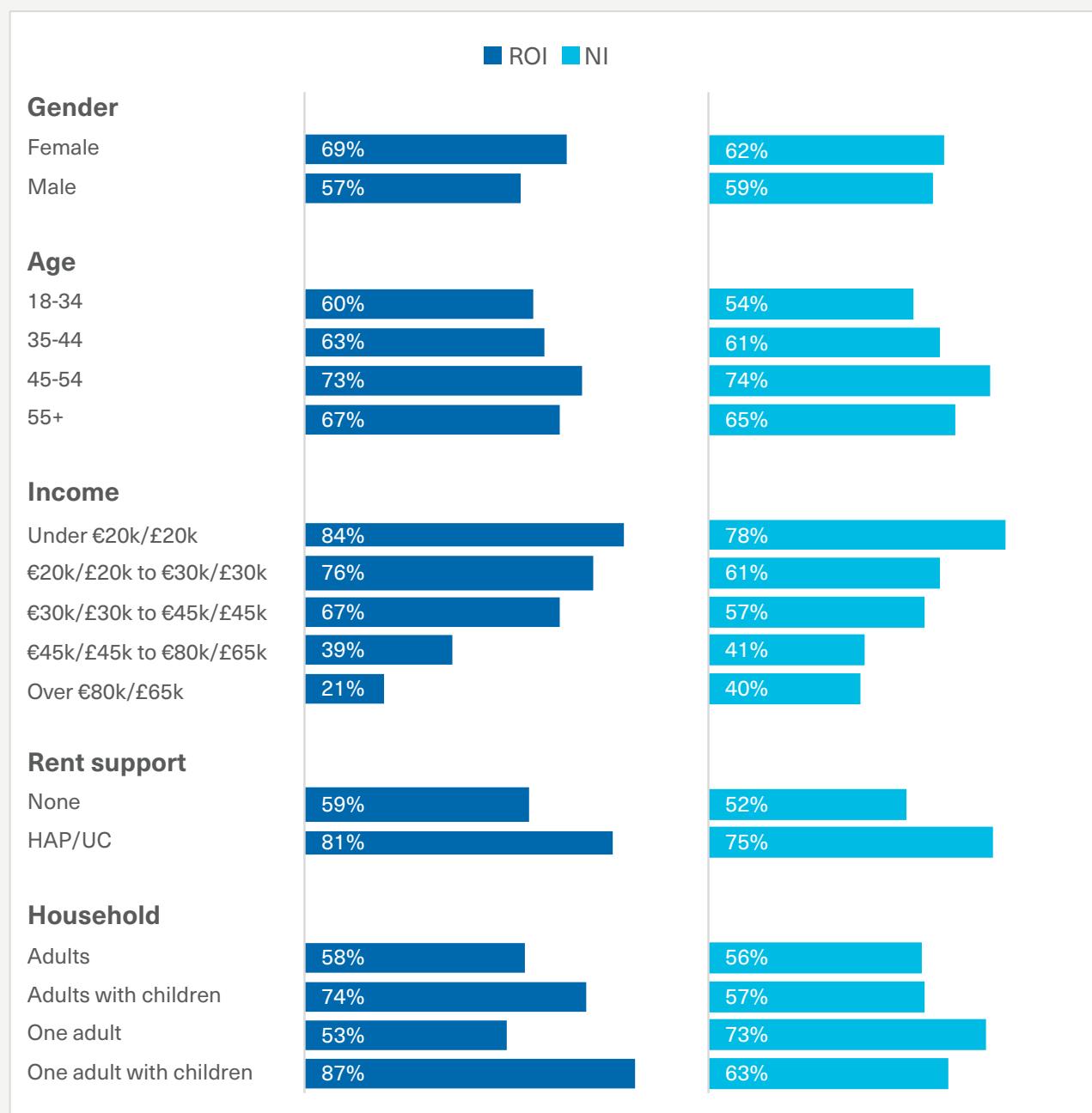
Our research revealed that 63% of renters in ROI and 61% of renters in NI struggle to pay both their bills and the rent. The most significant differences were observed across income levels. In NI, 78% of respondents earning less than £20,000 find it difficult to cover bills and rent, compared to 40% of those earning over £65,000. This gap is similar in ROI, where 84% of respondents earning under €20,000 struggle to pay bills and rent, while only 21% of those earning over €80,000 facing the same difficulty. At the time of the research, £65,000 was equivalent to €78,000. The higher proportion of higher earners struggling in NI is therefore surprising, considering they spend a smaller share of their income on rent. However, this may also be a function of rising personal debt and high interests rate in NI,³¹ compared with stronger savings in ROI.³²

³⁰ Central Statistics Office. (2025). Survey on Income and Living Conditions (SILC) 2024 – Poverty. CSO Ireland. <https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silc/surveyonincomeandlivingconditionssilc2024/poverty/>

³¹ Advice NI & Consumer Council. (2025). Average personal debt in Northern Ireland doubles as household bills rocket. The Irish News. <https://www.irishnews.com/news/northern-ireland/average-personal-debt-in-northern-ireland-doubles-as-household-bills-rocket-U4KYJCX5KVFJHJ3LMQAAYO2Q4Q/> https://www.consumerCouncil.org.uk/sites/default/files/2023-10/Importance_of_Consumer_to_the_NI_Economy.pdf

³² <https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-hs/householdssavingq12025>

Figure 20. Share of the population struggling to pay their bills by demographic category – 'Is it a struggle to pay bills (pay for groceries etc.) and pay the rent?'



Across the island, female renters are more likely to report that they struggle to pay bills compared with male renters, with 69% and 57% (ROI) and 62% and 59% (NI) reporting this, respectively. In ROI, single parents are overwhelmingly likely to report difficulty paying their bills, at 87%. Those in receipt of HAP or UC are also very likely to indicate that they are struggling to pay their bills, at 81% in ROI and 75% in NI. There is also a significant overlap between these two groups.

Rent arrears

Debt accumulation is strongly linked to housing costs and essential living expenses. A recent Housing Rights analysis of data from the Northern Ireland Department for Communities found that 82% of private renters in receipt of housing benefits faced a shortfall between their Local Housing Allowance and their actual rent costs.³³

Across the two jurisdictions, the level of rent arrears is quite similar, with 7% of renters in ROI and 9% in NI experiencing difficulties. The larger share in NI reflects a dynamic mentioned in the previous section. Although rents account for a higher share of net income in ROI, tenants in NI are more likely to indicate that they are in arrears. This is perhaps the result of higher personal debt levels and higher interest rates in NI, which put additional pressure on tenants in that jurisdiction.

There are also subtle differences in the causes of arrears. While the sample sizes for those in arrears are small, there is some evidence of differences between ROI (n= 59) and NI (n=42). In ROI, the main drivers were unexpected bills or large payments (37%), rent increases (37%) and a decline or loss of income (24%). Single parents and HAP recipients are most vulnerable to facing unexpected bills or large payments in ROI. In NI, family and relationship issues feature more prominently. The leading reasons given for rent arrears in NI are changes in family circumstances (43%) and unexpected large bills or payments (38%). The third most common cause is relationship breakdown at 32%, compared with just 5% in ROI. Across both jurisdictions, those on lower incomes, single-parent households, and those receiving housing support are two to three times more likely to fall into arrears.

The prominence of ‘relationship breakdown’ in NI could perhaps be explained by the fact that it drives more homelessness in ROI. While the relationship breakdown is a factor in homelessness in both jurisdictions, there is some evidence of it being a more prominent factor in ROI (Dublin Regional Housing Executive, 2025³⁴) when compared with NI (NISRA, 2025³⁵). When we include hidden homelessness it constitutes a larger share of the overall ROI population (Simon Communities of Ireland, 2024³⁶).

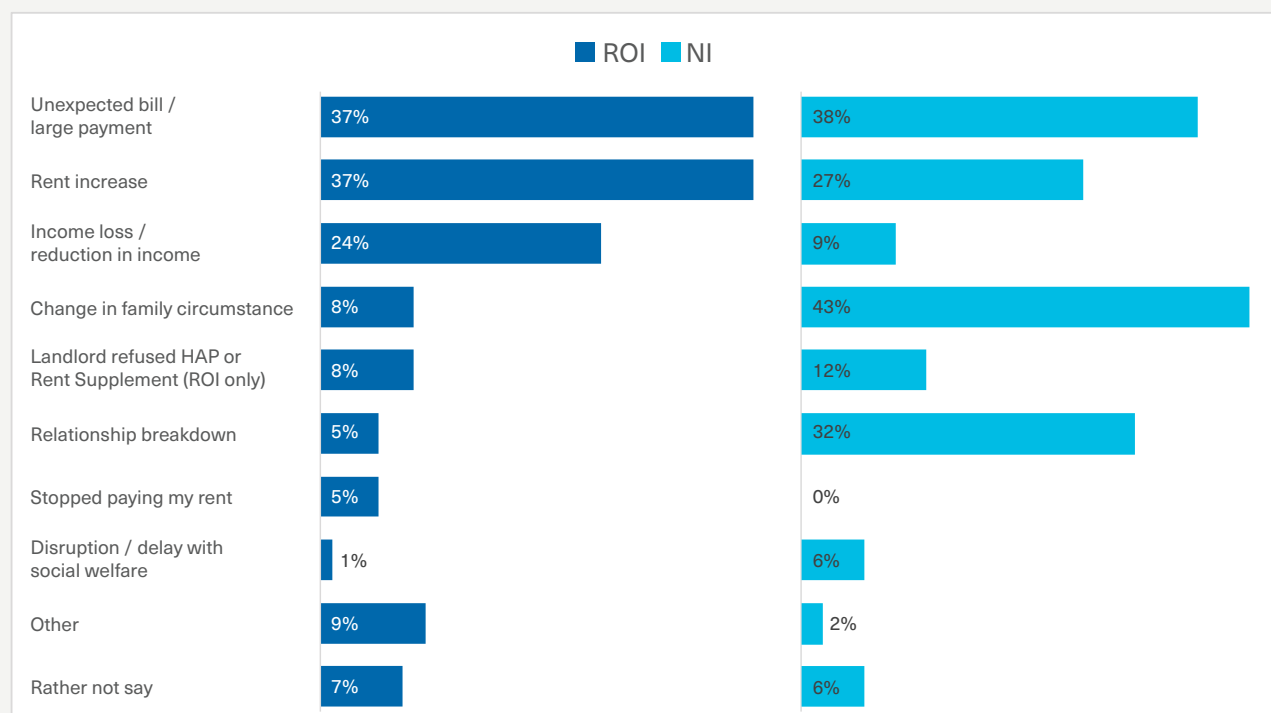
³³ Housing Rights (14 September 2023). Press release: 82% of private renters in NI face shortfall between their housing benefit and cost of rent <https://www.housingrights.org.uk/professionals/news/press-release-82-private-renters-ni-face-shortfall-between-their-housing-benefit>

³⁴ Dublin Region Homeless Executive (2025). Monthly report on homelessness in the Dublin region – May 2025 (Homeless-update-63). Homeless Dublin. Retrieved from <https://www.homelessdublin.ie/content/files/Homeless-update-63-May-2025.pdf>

³⁵ Northern Ireland Statistics and Research Agency (NISRA) (2025). Households presented as homeless between October 2024 and March 2025 <https://www.nisra.gov.uk/news/7637-households-presented-homeless-between-october-2024-and-march-2025>

³⁶ Simon Communities of Ireland & Simon Community Northern Ireland. (2024). Under the Radar: Unveiling Hidden Homelessness Across the Island of Ireland <https://www.simon.ie/wp-content/uploads/2024/05/Under-the-Radar-Unveiling-Hidden-Homelessness-Across-the-Island-of-Ireland-FINAL-1.pdf>

Figure 21. Reasons for rent arrears – ‘Can you tell us how the arrears accrued? (select all that apply)’



The qualitative research helped us to understand in greater detail how tenants were responding to this financial pressure. It is worth stating that a large proportion felt that their rent was under market value. This was raised in both ROI and NI:

“I’m quite lucky with what I have for the price I’m paying.”

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Some of the renters in NI also remarked that they are getting a better deal than they would in ROI. Interviewees also expressed the concern that they needed to maintain this status quo. One tenant, Paul (NI) remarked that he believed the value for money was a ‘reciprocal relationship’, as his upkeep of the property was of value to the landlord:

“So that they [the landlord] doesn’t have to look for other tenants and run the risk of not getting good ones.”

— Paul, Northern Ireland

Several participants described an unspoken ‘don’t poke the bear’ dynamic between landlord and tenant, where requesting repairs could risk higher rents or eviction. Especially in ROI, the fear of reputational damage appeared periodically in testimonials. One respondent explained that their attitudes made them reticent to raise complaints due to potential consequences, and others referred to the implications on their relationship with their landlord.

“In a small town, you don’t want to be the bad apple... everyone knows everyone.”

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

“You feel if you in any way cause issue or cost, you create a vulnerability.”

— Paul, Northern Ireland

“My housemate is paranoid... advising me not to complain and report on things.”

— Sarah, Northern Ireland

The financial stress faced by NI tenants was apparent across a range of circumstances. Edel, who recently accepted a new lease, felt she was not getting value for money. She described being served a one-month notice to quit from her previous tenancy, which meant she needed to find a new property very quickly. This left her with a lack of choice:

“I felt like I had to take something; I had no other choice at the time. But it’s definitely not value for money at all. It’s unfurnished, and I’m paying through the nose for it, and it’s very isolated, and it should be at least £150 cheaper than what it is”

— Edel, Northern Ireland

This search was particularly harrowing for Edel, who is renting by herself. As she explained, the expenses “might be more tolerable” (financially) if she could split them with someone else. She is also supposed to be exempt from paying rates because of her entitlement to rates relief through UC. However, her application has not been processed yet, which further contributed to her sense of financial insecurity:

"I get Universal Credit, and that gets paid to me, and I pay it straight into the landlord, because I have to top it up. I'm also entitled to rates relief, which I applied for back in May, and I still haven't got it. And anytime I ring, they tell me that they haven't assigned anybody to deal with it yet, and they don't give me any time frame. And that's quite a significant amount of my rent that I'm entitled to have free or at least subsidised."

— Edel, Northern Ireland

Another tenant, a single parent, described her depleting savings:

"Whatever meagre savings I had before are completely depleted. Only for I get help from my brothers, they pay for different things for the kids, my kids wouldn't be doing any extracurriculars... I make ends meet, and you do without stuff, you know, you have to."

— Triona, Republic of Ireland

Another explained how she and her husband have had to completely adjust their lifestyle to prioritise rent:

"We are home bodies because we have to be... We even spoke about it last night. My husband said, 'Are we ever going to be able to go on a holiday?' I said, 'No, just get over it'... You can either be grumpy about it or accept it and move on."

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

Niall's experience below illustrates a particularly precarious situation as someone who needed to take time off work due to illness. He reported using his savings to stay afloat and that his housing status is becoming more insecure as time goes on:

"Lately, it's becoming increasingly difficult for me to pay the rent and everything else because I've been out of work sick for the last couple of months, and I've burned through my savings paying the rent and utilities and stuff like that."

— Niall, Republic of Ireland

Our quantitative analysis also shows that those receiving HAP are particularly vulnerable to financial shocks, with over a fifth (22%) of HAP recipients reporting rent arrears. Our interviews shed some light on why the scheme fails to protect renters from financial pressure. Among those eligible for HAP who we interviewed, all had to make additional top-up rental payments beyond the scheme's contribution. Triona revealed that she is on the maximum level of HAP but still needs to "top up" her rent. Barry noted that it is not enough for him and believes that, over time, the total rent cost will become unsustainable. Patrice thinks that HAP presents a distorted view of the private rental sector:

"There's a family that are getting HAP near me. They're paying extra money on top of their HAP, but the HAP is what's inflating the price of the rent."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Other interviewees who are ineligible for HAP also explained that they can still feel the same severe financial pressure:

"We applied for HAP, and HAP told us that wouldn't work, apparently, because I don't know how they work it, but apparently we earn too much. I don't understand."

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

These issues around HAP are supported by government research.³⁷ The original intention of the HAP scheme was that payments would cover the full cost of a household's rent to a maximum limit, with the household paying a differential rent to the local authority. However, the availability of rental properties which come within the current HAP limits is declining due to rising rents. In 2022, the ESRI found that up to 28% per cent of HAP recipients were making additional top-up payments to landlords over the statutory limit of 30% of net income.³⁸

Overall, affordability is marginally tighter in ROI compared to NI, especially among those on higher incomes. However, it seems that the levels of debt and savings held by households also have effects, resulting in more tenants in NI falling into arrears. Perhaps there is also a higher level of apparent compliance with demands for rent in ROI due to the intensity of the rental market. In interviews, renters in ROI were more likely to report that they have to cut back on spending and struggle to save after paying rent, with the limitations of HAP further undermining financial stability for lower-income households.

³⁷ Office of the Ombudsman (2025). Investigation of the Housing Assistance Payment (HAP) Scheme <https://ombudsman.ie/en/publication/2ae60-investigation-of-the-hap-scheme/>

³⁸ Doolan, M., Roantree, B., and Slaymaker, R. (2022). Low-income renters and housing supports (ESRI Research Series No. 141). Economic and Social Research Institute. https://www.esri.ie/system/files/publications/RS141_1.pdf

Rights & Protections

Access to clear and reliable information is vital to fairness in the private rental sector. When tenants understand their rights and landlords recognise their responsibilities, housing relationships are more stable, and disputes are less frequent. Research shows that a lack of awareness about housing laws and regulations leaves many renters vulnerable to insecurity and poor living conditions.

In ROI, research from O'Callaghan, Boyle and McArdle (2021)³⁹ found that limited knowledge of legal protections prevents tenants from challenging unfair practices, which reinforces power imbalances within the private rental market. Fox, O'Mahony and Sweeney (2020)⁴⁰ similarly argue that legal rights alone are insufficient and that tenants must be able to access and act on those rights if they are to have any real value. In NI, Wallace and Dempsey (2021)⁴¹ report that many renters remain uncertain about their entitlements around repairs, deposits and notice periods, even after recent government reforms.

Knowledge of rights

Knowledge of tenant rights is important for protecting renters' interests. However, when renters are unaware of these rights, it can lead to increased difficulties navigating the rental sector. This section aims to evaluate tenants' subjective understanding of their rights, their landlords' responsibilities and regulations across the island by asking respondents to assess their knowledge of these matters.

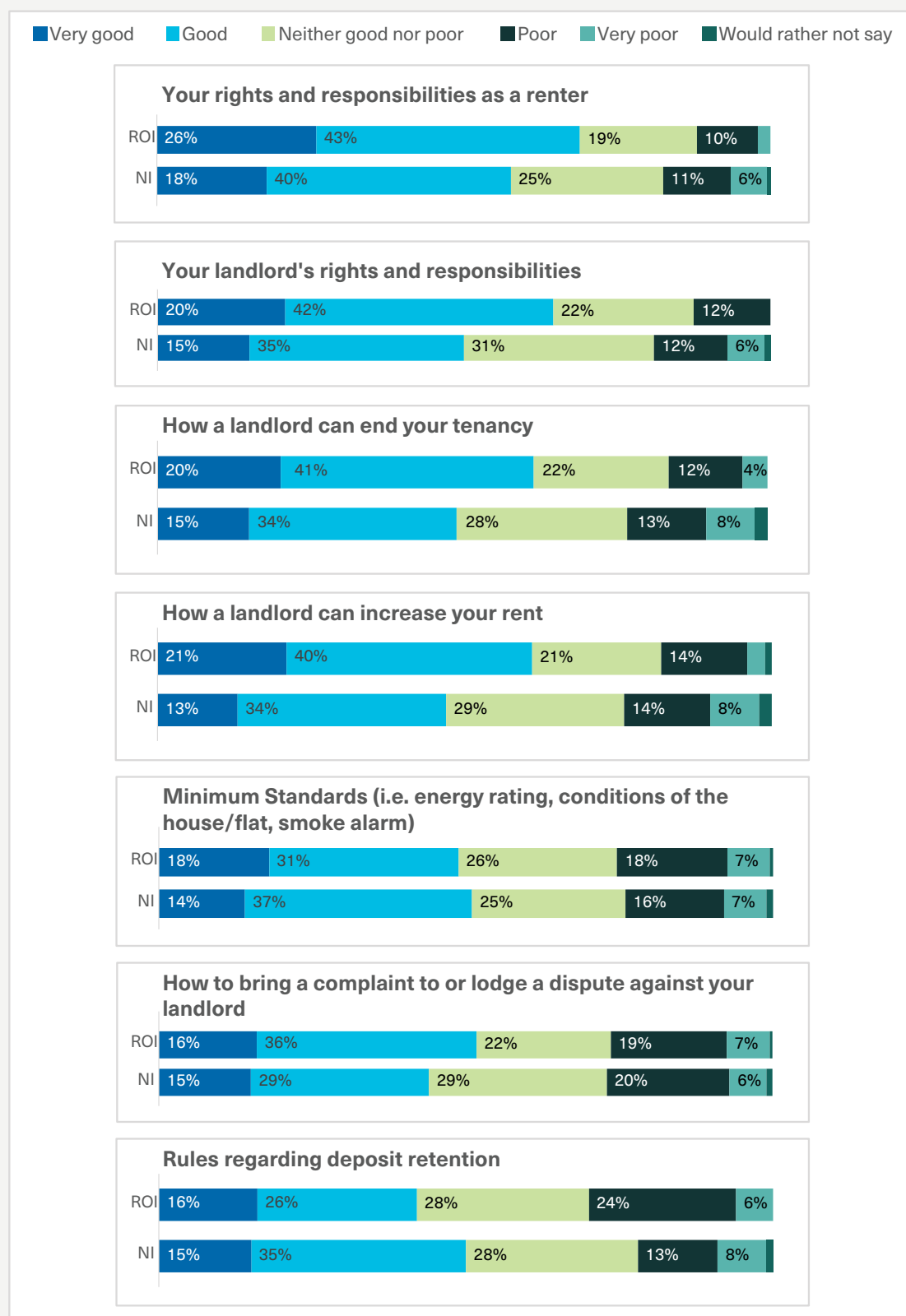
Across the island, most renters (66%) rated their knowledge of their rights and responsibilities as a renter as 'good' or 'very good', with a small minority (14%) reporting their knowledge as 'poor' or 'very poor'. While renters believe that they have some knowledge of their own rights and responsibilities, they tend to know less about the specifics, such as how to lodge a complaint against their landlord. Renters in NI appear to have less confidence in their evaluation of their own knowledge across almost all categories. In ROI, knowledge is strongest among older renters and higher earners, with 87% of those over 65 and 79% of renters with incomes above €80,000 reporting that they have a solid grasp of their rights and responsibilities. In NI, the differences between the demographic categories are much less clear.

³⁹ O'Callaghan, C., Boyle, M., & McArdle, R. (2021). Renting in Ireland: Power, policy and precarity in the private rented sector. *Irish Geography*, 54(2), 145–164.

⁴⁰ Fox O'Mahony, L., & Sweeney, J. (2020). Home: Rights, responsibilities and the role of law in housing governance. *Journal of Property, Planning and Environmental Law*, 12(3), 179–196.

⁴¹ Wallace, A., & Dempsey, K. (2021). Understanding the private rented sector in Northern Ireland: Regulation, reform and the renter experience. *Housing Studies*, 36(10), 1627–1645.

Figure 22. How would you rate your knowledge of [...]'

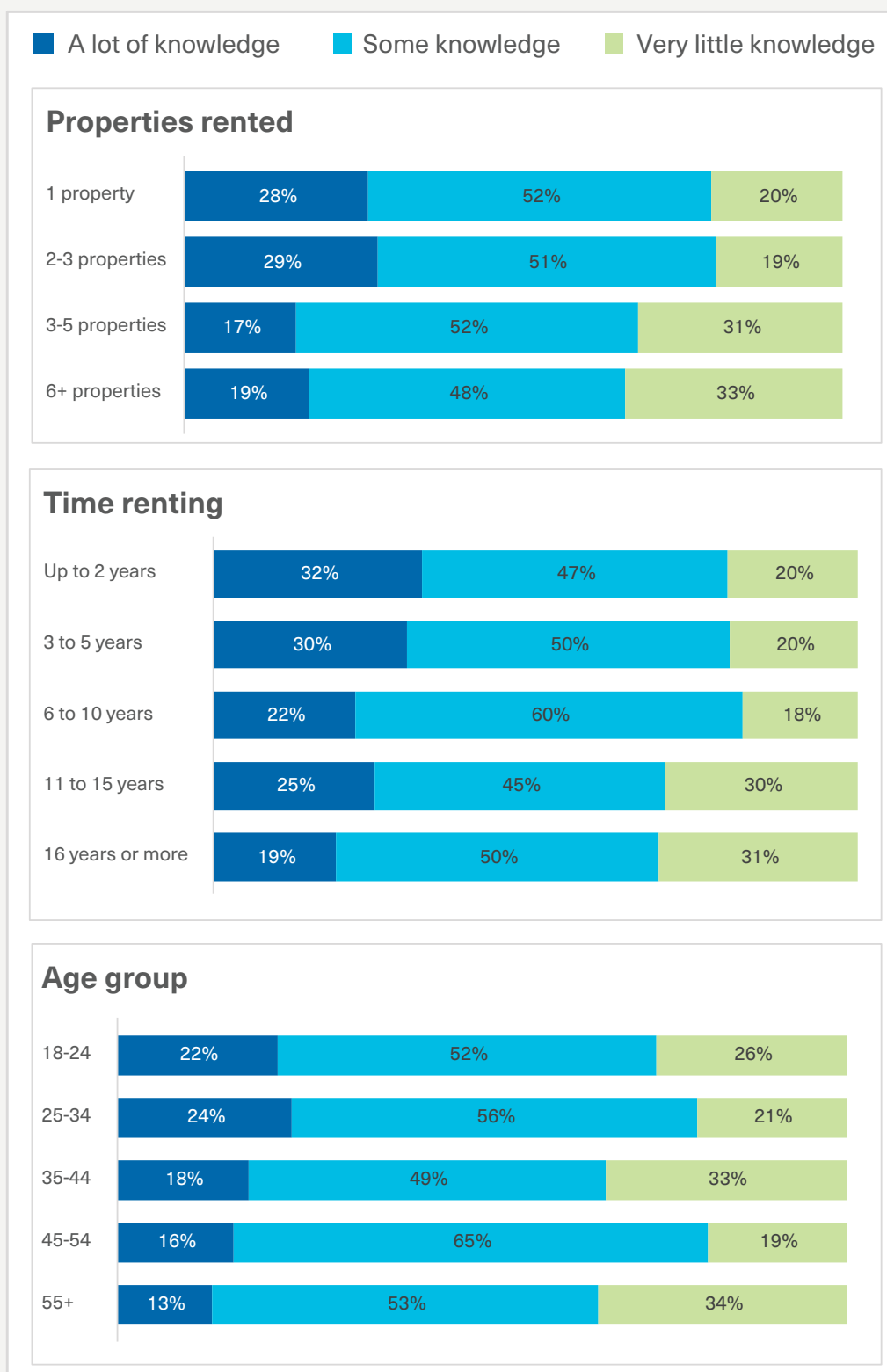


Fewer renters felt confident about their understanding of landlord rights, with 59% reporting 'good' or 'very good' knowledge. Across the island of Ireland, 58% believe they understand how a landlord can end their tenancy. Broken down by jurisdiction, this is lower in NI (49%) than in ROI (61%). Similarly, 61% of renters in ROI are confident about their understanding of rent increases, compared with 47% in NI. When asked about dispute procedures, 52% in the ROI report understood these procedures compared with 44% in NI. Knowledge generally increases across income levels in both jurisdictions.

Renters in NI had stronger levels of knowledge regarding deposit retention and minimum standards. Half (50%) of renters rated their knowledge of deposit rules as 'good' or 'very good' compared with 42% in ROI. Regarding minimum standards, about half of renters in both jurisdictions rate their understanding as either 'good' or 'very good'. Awareness of deposit rules in NI increases with income, with 81% of those earning over £65,000 reporting 'good' or 'very good' knowledge compared with just 35% of those earning under £20,000. In ROI, confidence is weaker across the board, with younger cohorts having the lowest perceived knowledge.

We can simplify these responses into a single variable classifying each respondent as either having 'A lot of knowledge' (those who tend to rate themselves highly across various knowledge items), 'Some knowledge' or 'Very little knowledge' (those who rate themselves poorly). Interestingly, there isn't the strong correlation that one might otherwise expect between a respondent's overall perceived knowledge and factors like the amount of time spent in the sector and the number of properties lived in, as one might expect. Perhaps it is a case of the more one knows, the more one realises what they do not know.

Figure 23. Overall knowledge broken down by the amount of time and the number of properties rented.



Qualitative research on rights

In our qualitative interviews, renters were asked about their rights as tenants and their main source of information on those rights. Across both jurisdictions, many renters described a 'need to know' attitude towards their rights, meaning they only consult them in moments of need. This leaves some with a limited to mid-level working knowledge of the finer details:

"[After experiencing conflict with her landlord] I know a lot more [about my rights] after what I experienced earlier in the year."

— Edel, Northern Ireland

"I only ever look into my rights when something goes wrong, otherwise you just get on with it."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

In NI, interviewees could more regularly recite the regulations on deposit protection and retention. However, understanding of more procedural protections, such as rent increases and notices to quit, was less strong, and there was a lower level of knowledge on which charities or institutions to turn to for help. Oliver (NI) noted that his letting agent provided him with a handbook at the beginning of his tenancy that contained, among other things, information on his rights and the details of local charities and government agencies. That said, Oliver admitted that he could not remember the legal terms, reflecting a surface-level awareness as opposed to active engagement.

In ROI, renters more readily name Citizens Information and charities such as Threshold as institutions they could consult. The mechanisms for enforcing the law were brought into question, however, as one tenant indicated he had seen various examples of illegal evictions during his time in the private rental sector. He highlighted both the weakness of enforcement and the precarity faced by tenants:

"Rights are only as good as their enforcement... You can have all the rights in the world, but if you're afraid to use them, they're not worth much."

— Dylan, Republic of Ireland

Edel's experience of the private rental sector helps to underscore this broader concern about inconsistencies between tenants' legal entitlements and their actual enforcement:

"You can know the rules, but that doesn't mean the council or the landlord follow them."

— Edel, Northern Ireland

Another renter in ROI was optimistic in relation to the introduction of new renter protections, yet indicated pessimism in relation to access to justice:

“Unless you’ve got money or support, [regulations] might as well not exist.”
— Triona, Republic of Ireland

The interviews capture the gap between formal rights and their practical application. In the survey, 28% of renters across the island feel some level of discomfort in contacting their landlord, letting agent or landlord representative if an issue arises. This reticence to report any breaches of tenant rights existed in both jurisdictions. As Lyn succinctly stated:

“Don’t poke the bear.”
— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

Renters believe there is an unspoken agreement not to approach their landlord with too many problems:

“If you in any way cause an issue or cost, you create a vulnerability.”
— Paul, Northern Ireland

The protections offered by RPZ regulations in ROI meant very little to some renters, in terms of housing security. One tenant reported how the fear of retribution prevented her from raising concerns about illegal rent increases:

“My landlord has put my rent up twice this year, well over the 2% and I didn’t open my mouth. I’m not going to do anything to annoy my landlord.”
— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

Deposit protection scheme

Since 2013, all deposits in NI have been protected under regulations requiring registration or transfer of the deposit within 28 days. Landlords must explain dispute processes, reasons for withholding deposits and refund procedures to tenants. Disputes are arbitrated through an independent service. Previous research has shown that 9 out of 10 tenants are confident that their deposit is secure, and most landlords in NI support the scheme, considering it fair and efficient.

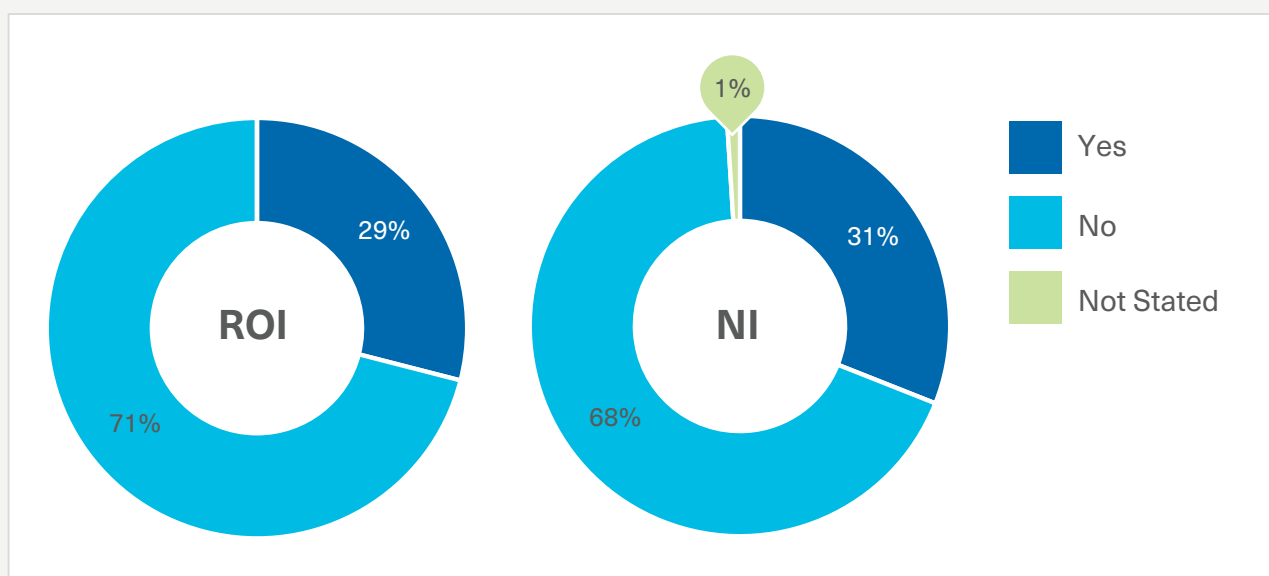
A similar deposit protection scheme was also legislated for in ROI in 2015 but has yet to be implemented. The proposal would see landlords storing deposits with the RTB for the duration of tenancies. In Q2 of 2025, 20% of applications for dispute resolution

made to the RTB were in relation to deposit retention, which represents the second-highest incidence across all dispute categories.⁴² Between 2019 and 2021, 73% to 94% of deposit-related cases were adjudicated in favour of tenants, with the RTB advising that deposits should be either fully or partially refunded.

The absence of such a procedure leaves tenants vulnerable when deposits are unfairly withheld. Research by Threshold in ROI estimates that over €390 million is held by private landlords in deposits at any given time.⁴³ Lima (2025)⁴⁴ finds that deposit-related disputes make up a large share of complaints to Threshold and the RTB, as well as a steady flow of cases brought before the Small Claims Court.

Our research asked if renters have ever had their security deposit unfairly kept by their landlord. Across the island, 30% reported that they have had their deposit unfairly withheld by their landlord at the end of a tenancy. This figure is, perhaps surprisingly, nearly identical in NI and ROI. Although the Tenancy Deposit Scheme signifies a sophisticated aspect of housing policy in NI, there are notable gaps in practice: (1) compliance, as it is reported that over half of private rental sector tenancies in NI do not use the deposit protection scheme;⁴⁵ and (2) tenant knowledge, as our research indicates that awareness regarding tenant rights remains relatively weak in NI, including in this specific area.

Figure 24. Deposit retention in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘Have you ever had your deposit unfairly kept by the landlord?’



⁴² Residential Tenancies Board (2025). RTB Director's Quarterly Update. Dublin: RTB <https://rtb.ie/data-insights/rtb-data-hub/dispute-applications/>

⁴³ Threshold (2023). Deposit Protection Scheme Proposal. Dublin: Threshold.

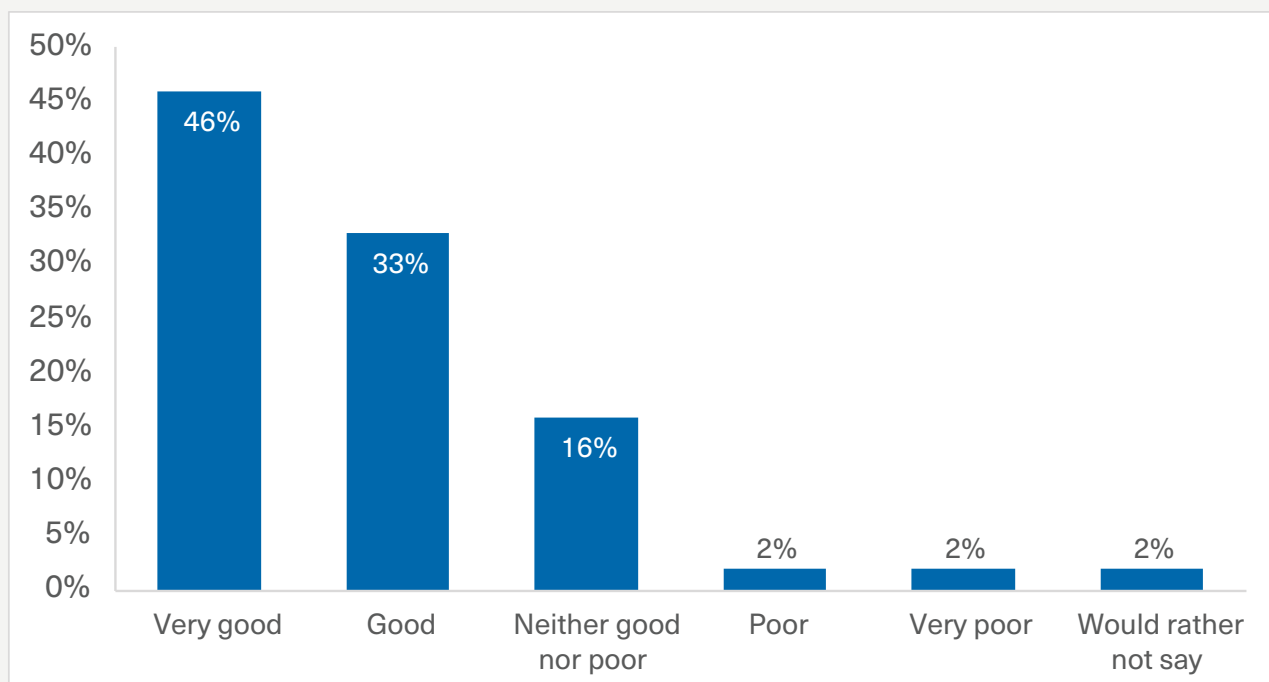
⁴⁴ Lima, R. (2025). Renting at the frontier: Protecting the rights of licensees in Ireland. Dublin: Threshold.

⁴⁵ TDS Group (2024). Statistical Briefing 2023/24

In NI, our research suggests that those in receipt of housing supports are more likely than those who do not receive any rental support to report having had their deposit unfairly withheld (39%). This is perhaps because these tenants are deemed to have fewer housing options, a greater dependence on their current tenancy given the scarcity of options, and less financial capacity to challenge their landlord.

By contrast, in ROI a smaller but still significant number (22%) of those on HAP report that they have had their deposit unfairly kept by their landlord. This may reflect the advantages of a more structured benefits system, where housing support payments are typically made directly from the local authority to the landlord. Landlords administering HAP tenancies are also, arguably, operating in a more regulated environment. Those in receipt of Homeless HAP can access schemes where their local council covers the deposit on their behalf. In contrast, under the UC system in NI, housing support payments are usually made directly to the tenant, potentially increasing the risk of landlord noncompliance.

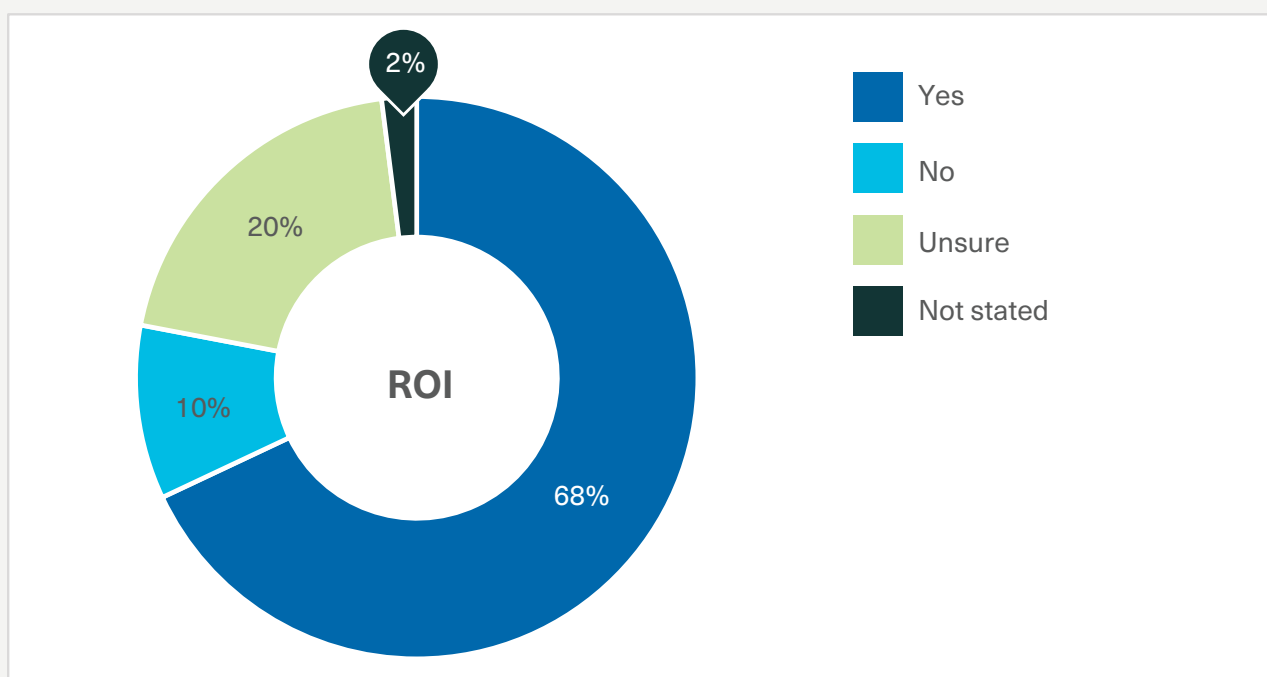
Figure 25. Opinion on Northern Ireland's deposit protection scheme (Republic of Ireland sample only) – 'In Northern Ireland, the law requires landlords to protect your deposit by placing it in a Deposit Protection Scheme. This means that by law, a third party, not your landlord, holds your deposit. What do you think of this scheme?'



Our survey shows there is a strong interest in establishing a deposit protection scheme in the ROI. When this scheme is explained to respondents, it becomes clear that it would be popular among renters in ROI, with 46% stating that the introduction would be ‘very good’ and 33% saying it would be ‘good’. Just 4% rate it as ‘poor’ or ‘very poor’. When asked whether they would avail of such a system, the number is invariably smaller but still very strong, with 68% of respondents preferring their deposit to be covered by such a scheme and 10% opposed.

Such a scheme is especially popular among younger tenants, with 72% of renters aged between 18 and 34 in favour, compared to 57% of those aged over 65. This difference may be because younger tenants are more likely to be in less secure tenancies, or it might reflect older renters’ concerns about new schemes that could be technical in nature. Renters in larger urban areas (73%) and those earning over €45,000 (73%) were especially supportive. As security deposits are usually equivalent to one month’s rent, this would be a higher amount for these tenants, which may explain their higher level of support for the scheme. It may also illustrate greater underlying levels of institutional trust that exist among those with higher incomes.⁴⁶

Figure 26. Support for a deposit protection scheme among renters in the Republic of Ireland only – ‘Would you prefer if your deposit was protected by a ‘Deposit Protection Scheme’ instead of being held by your landlord (i.e. a third party other than your landlord would hold onto your deposit)?’



⁴⁶ Edelman (2025). 2025 Edelman Trust Barometer: Ireland Report. Edelman Ireland https://www.edelman.ie/sites/g/files/aatuss306/files/2025-03/2025%20Edelman%20Trust%20Barometer_Ireland%20Report.pdf

In NI, qualitative interviews confirmed what was suspected regarding noncompliance with the deposit protection scheme:

"[I] had to beg [my landlord] to put my deposit in a scheme."

— Edel, Northern Ireland

In ROI, renters expressed interest in the scheme:

"People are really, really scared going to landlords to get a deposit back, because of tiny things."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Interviewees favoured having an independent third party that could hold deposits and adjudicate end-of-tenancy disputes, with landlords submitting evidence of damage and the third party determining the outcome. Patrice believes that for such an arrangement, the landlord can report "what's been broken, x, y and z," and the third party can resolve it more equitably:

"It'd be so much fairer if someone neutral just held the money — it would take the stress out of it."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

Taken together, these testimonies suggest that a deposit protection scheme would be widely welcomed in ROI. However, as experience in NI shows, effective implementation would require robust enforcement to ensure compliance among landlords.

Repairs & Landlord Relations

Standards of repair and maintenance are essential for ensuring safe and sustainable housing. Across Ireland, research shows that inadequate repair standards and weak enforcement remain persistent challenges. In 2024, local authorities inspected over 62,000 private rental properties, finding that 61% failed to meet minimum standards on first inspection.⁴⁷ Reports specifically highlight the very high levels of damp present in rental accommodation in ROI.⁴⁸ In NI, the Northern Ireland Housing Executive's House Condition Survey 2016 found that 20% of private rented dwellings had internal disrepair while 42% required external repairs and 11% failed to meet the Decent Homes Standard.⁴⁹ There has no update on this data since then. Looking across the UK, Fitzpatrick and Stephens (2020)⁵⁰ note that while housing policy has diverged across devolved administrations, enforcement of property standards remains largely reactive and dependent on tenant reporting – a model that often fails to protect those in precarious housing situations.

Outstanding repairs

In ROI, 64% of renters report at least one unresolved issue lasting four weeks or more, while in NI, the figure is 59%. The most common problem across both jurisdictions is damp or mould in the home. There is also a significant difference in the prevalence of mould or damp between the two jurisdictions. In ROI, this is an ongoing issue in over one-third of homes (35%). This is slightly less common in NI, where it affects between one-fifth and one-quarter of rental homes (22%).

Structural and heating and ventilation issues appear to be slightly more common in ROI compared to NI, with the cost of heating (22% ROI, 15% NI), poor lighting/ventilation (16% ROI, 11% NI) and issues with hot/cold water (13% ROI, 6% NI) all marginally more prevalent. Other issues, such as broken windows, faulty bathrooms or showers, broken alarms, etc., have similar prevalence between the two jurisdictions.

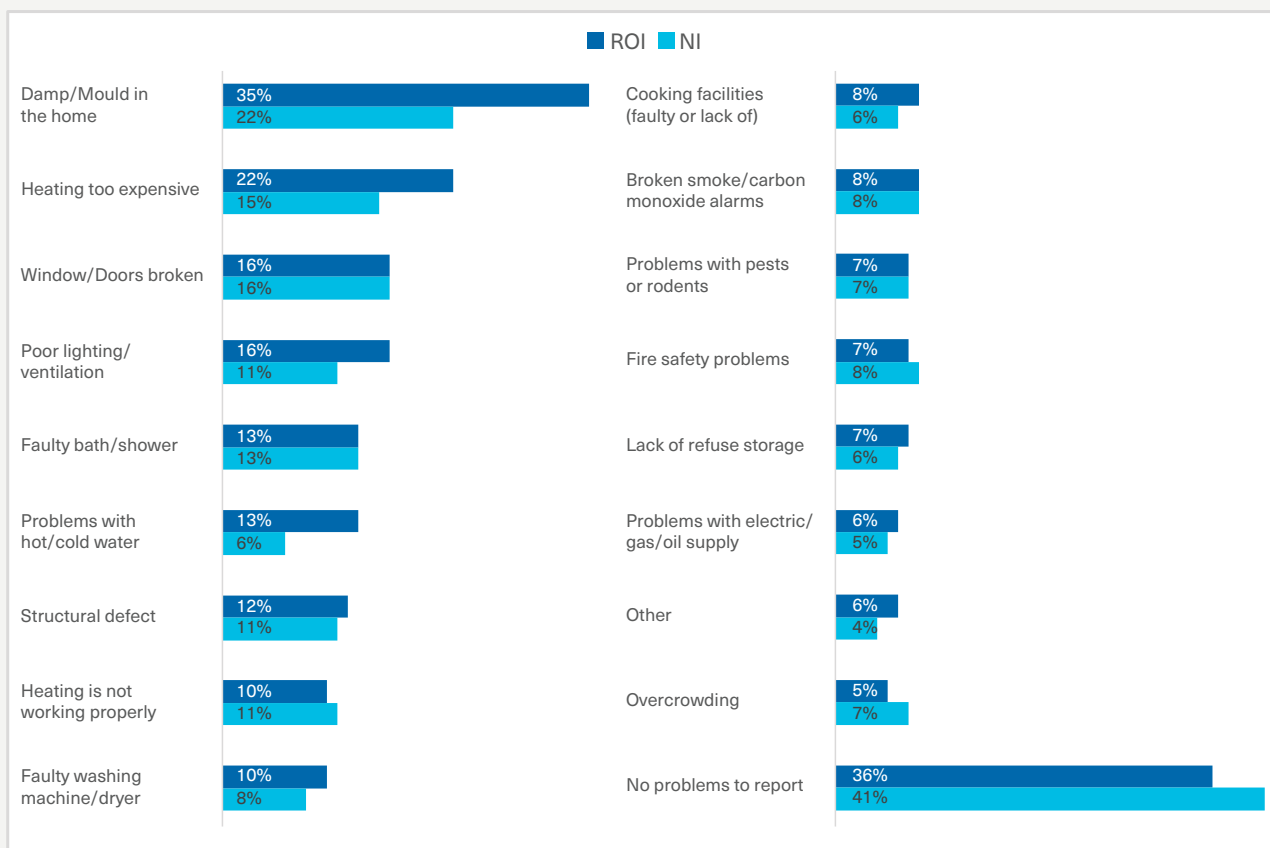
⁴⁷ Department of Housing, Local Government and Heritage. (n.d.). Private housing market statistics: Private rented inspections. Government of Ireland. Retrieved December 15, 2025, from <https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-housing-local-government-and-heritage/publications/private-housing-market-statistics/#private-rented-inspections>

⁴⁸ The Housing Agency. (2023). Residential satisfaction in Ireland 2023 (National Study of Housing Experiences, Attitudes and Aspirations in Ireland)

⁴⁹ Northern Ireland Housing Executive (NIHE). (2022). Northern Ireland House Condition Survey: Main Report 2022. Belfast: NIHE

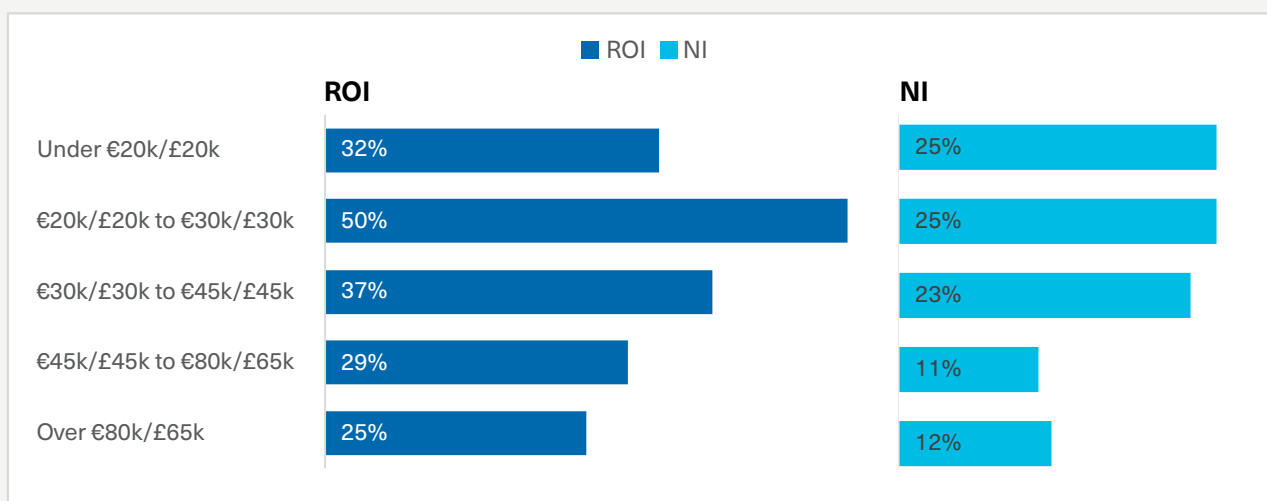
⁵⁰ Fitzpatrick, S., & Stephens, M. (2020). Housing policy in the UK: Continuity and change. *Housing Studies*, 35(9), 1578–1599

Figure 27. 'Do you currently have any of the following issues with poor standards/ outstanding repairs in your home for at least four weeks?'



The issue of mould or damp is extremely common for city-based renters (40%), 18-34-year-olds (42%), multiple-adult households with no children (39%), and those earning between €20,000 and €30,000 (50%). The issue is quite common in ROI, even for those on high incomes, such as renters earning salaries of over €80,000 (25%). This perhaps reflects an older housing stock in the ROI private rental sector.

Figure 28. Reporting of damp or mould by income category in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern (NI) – ‘Do you currently have any of the following issues with poor standards/outstanding repairs in your home for at least four weeks? – Damp/Mould in the home’



Heating issues are most likely to be noticed by older renters, who are perhaps more acutely aware of these issues, with a third of over-65 renters in ROI reporting that their heating is too expensive. Over-65s are perhaps more reliant on heating, and therefore inadequate insulation poses a more significant risk to poverty.⁵¹ Single-parent households in ROI also report more problems across many categories compared with the average ROI renter: they report the highest incidence of problems with heating, broken windows/doors, lighting, ventilation, bathroom and structural integrity compared with other household types.

In interviews, renters described problems of persistent damp and inadequate landlord responses. After notifying her landlord about the damp, one renter expressed their dismay:

“He just ignored us, and then it got ugly. He gave us notice and said his family were moving in.”

— Lyn, Republic of Ireland

⁵¹ Haran, N., Butler, P. & Finnerty, J. (2023). Double Deficit: Older and Ageing Persons in the Irish Private Rental Sector: <https://threshold.ie/wp-content/uploads/2023/05/Double-Deficit.pdf>

In respect of damp issues, one renter in ROI recalled being told to:

"Just open the windows."

— Dylan, Republic of Ireland

Another renter, Triona (ROI), observed that remedial efforts often failed to address root causes, where her landlord would just clean off or paint the damp rather than address the cause:

"You're just cleaning it; you're not getting rid of it."

— Triona, Republic of Ireland

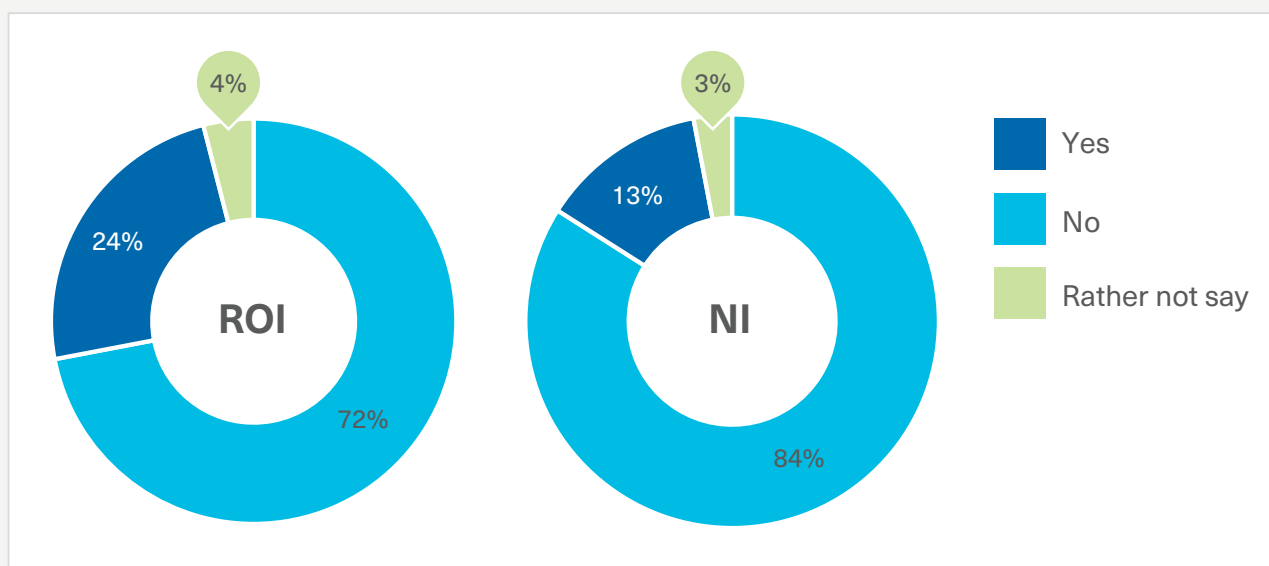
Reporting issues

As previously noted in interviews with tenants, the under-reporting of issues is prevalent among renters. The figures below suggest a higher prevalence of underreporting of issues in ROI. This may reflect the poorer quality of housing stock and, therefore, simply more issues to report. It might reflect slower responsiveness or, indeed, the inability to tackle what are often essentially structural issues with poor housing stock. Finally, as was well cited in the interviews, renters do not want to 'poke the bear' for fear of repercussions that may see them evicted.

The 2020 Threshold report showed how market dynamics are a key part of understanding why tenants do not seek redress for outstanding issues.⁵² Interviewees indicated that they were unwilling to raise an issue with their landlord as they were concerned that by contacting their landlord, it might lead to a 'conflict trigger' that may precipitate a rent increase or notice of termination. In some cases, however, this may not simply be malice on behalf of the landlord, but the fear that reporting of issues such as rising damp might uncover a deeper structural issue that would require the tenant to leave the property temporarily. Our research also shows that while renters do, for the most part, report these issues, those in ROI are less likely to report problems than those in NI, with 72% in ROI reporting issues to landlords compared with 84% in NI.

⁵² Byrne, M., & McArdle, R. (2020). Security and Agency in the Irish Private Rental Sector. Threshold & University College Dublin / Maynooth University https://threshold.ie/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/security_and_agency_in_irish_private_rented_sector_july2020.pdf

Figure 29. Prevalence of under-reporting of issues in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘Have you reported these to the landlord?’ [Those with issues to report]



In interviews, experiences of having repairs resolved varied widely. Many participants, including those in NI where professional letting agents were involved, reported prompt responses for urgent issues. One tenant praised the letting agent who had managed her previous tenancy:

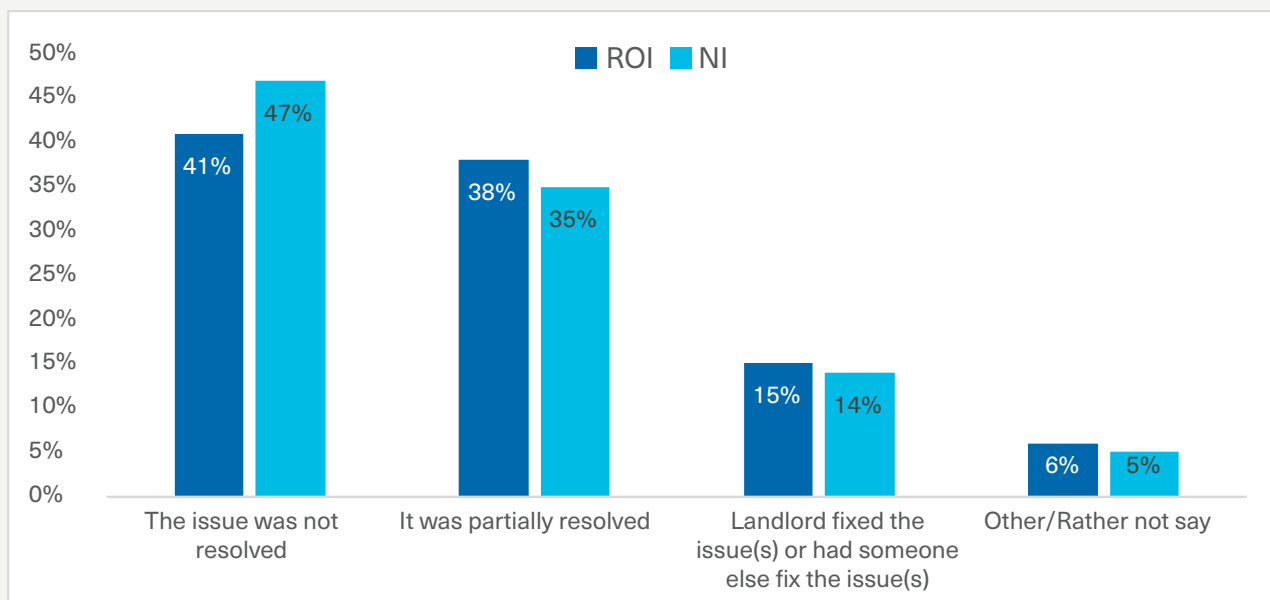
“You email them in the morning, and they’re on the phone a couple of hours later, and somebody’s coming.”

By contrast, in her current, landlord-managed tenancy, she felt:

“They don’t know how to be landlords. They don’t know how to take care of that.”
— Edel, Northern Ireland

While a minority described longer-term investment in their rental properties (e.g. installing solar panels), far more reported that major works and enduring problems were deferred or addressed with temporary fixes. One tenant, Sarah (NI) recounted a long-standing structural issue with her accommodation, where her landlord cycled through “a number of contractors” in attempts to cut costs and avoid sharing an expense with a neighbour. Ultimately, the landlord paid a less skilled contractor three times the neighbour’s quoted price to complete only half of the necessary works.

Figure 30. Resolution of repairs in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘What was the outcome of reporting the issue to the landlord?’ [Those with issues to report]

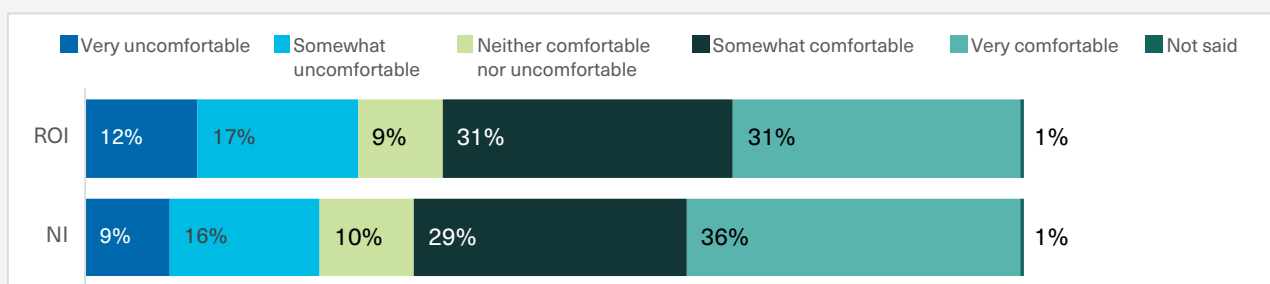


The likelihood that a landlord resolves an issue differs only slightly between ROI and NI. Renters in NI are marginally more likely to report a poor outcome, with 47% stating the issue was not resolved in NI compared to 41% in ROI.

Landlord relations

While most tenants indicate that they would be ‘comfortable’ or ‘very comfortable’ contacting their landlord if an issue arose, a sizeable minority indicate that they would not be comfortable. In ROI, 29% indicated that they would be either ‘uncomfortable’ or ‘very uncomfortable’ in contacting their landlord. In NI, this figure is marginally lower at 25%.

Figure 31. Level of comfort contacting one’s landlord in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – ‘How comfortable do you feel in contacting your landlord/letting agent/landlord’s representative if an issue arises?’



Among households experiencing damp or mould, nearly half (45%) in ROI report feeling 'uncomfortable' or 'very uncomfortable' contacting their landlord about any issue, rising to a majority (56%) in NI. This is double the underlying lack of comfort among NI tenants as a whole. These figures expose not just a profound power imbalance within the rental sector, but also the silence of renters living in houses with damp or mould, who risk their own health for the sake of access to accommodation.

In NI, interviewees reported their interactions with landlords via letting agents who handled these communications. Some valued this arrangement:

"I've never met my landlord, but my relationship with the agency is good."

— Paul, Northern Ireland

"The agency found me a new place after a notice to quit, so I avoided a convoluted search."

— Carolyn, Northern Ireland

There was, however, concern about how it reduced accountability:

"The agency doesn't seem to want him in the house. He hasn't set foot in it to see repairs or what needs [to be] done."

— Sarah, Northern Ireland

"In nine years he's inspected once. The only comment was that I'm living better than he is. Then came the rent increase."

— Paul, Northern Ireland

Several renters also described privacy concerns about routine agency inspections:

"It's like an invasion of privacy to have someone inspect my home to make sure I'm behaving."

— Stephen, Northern Ireland

Some perceived agents as primarily protecting landlords:

"Their only aim was to protect the landlord rather than the tenant."

— Edel, Northern Ireland

In ROI, renters were more likely to deal directly with landlords, and many praised the responsiveness of those relationships:

"She's very good and responsive... when she comes, she stays at the door."

— Patrice, Republic of Ireland

"If I ring him, he'll come down straight away."

— Niall, Republic of Ireland

At the same time, standards could lag:

"He's a nice man, but doesn't do everything he could with the house."

— Triona, Republic of Ireland

Across both jurisdictions, insecurity and a reluctance to complain were common. Past problems, or friends' experiences, made tenants wary of raising issues with the landlord:

"If he has to spend a fortune fixing bits and pieces, it might push him to say he's had enough."

— Nicola, Republic of Ireland

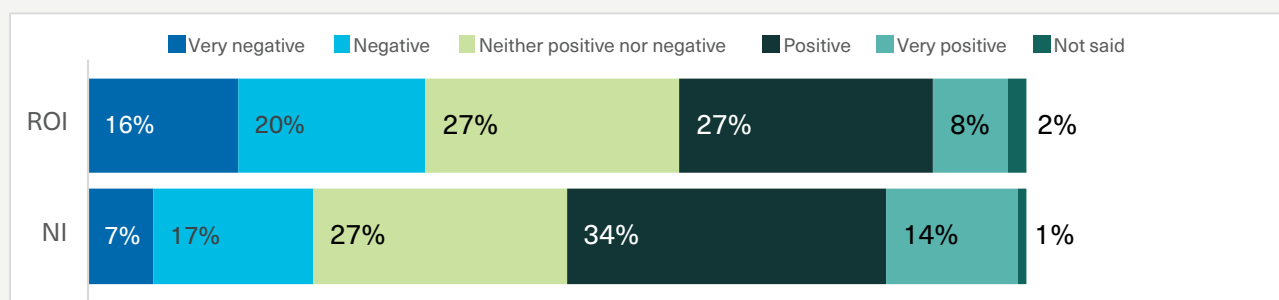
Overall Experience

Renting now forms a significant part of the housing landscape in both ROI and NI, with 18% of households in ROI and 17% of households in NI classified as being in the private rental sector.^{53,54} The sector remains marked by insecurity and limited stability for many tenants. Tenants frequently face rising rents, short leases and limited protection from eviction, which contribute to uncertainty and financial strain. In ROI, studies have shown that high housing costs and a shortage of long-term rental options have made renting increasingly unsustainable for younger and lower-income households.⁵⁵

Overall experience

Despite significant challenges in the sector, renters often feel more optimistic about their overall experience than might be expected. In ROI, a larger proportion of renters view their experiences negatively, with 36% describing their experience as 'negative' or 'very negative', while 35% see it as 'positive' or 'very positive'. There is a 2:1 ratio of those who are very negative compared to those who are very positive. In NI, attitudes are notably more positive, with 48% having a positive experience compared to 24% who see it as negative. The ratio of 'very positive' to 'very negative' experiences is also twice as high in favour of the very positive.

Figure 32. Overall experience of the private rental sector in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) – 'How would you rate your overall experience in the private rental sector?'



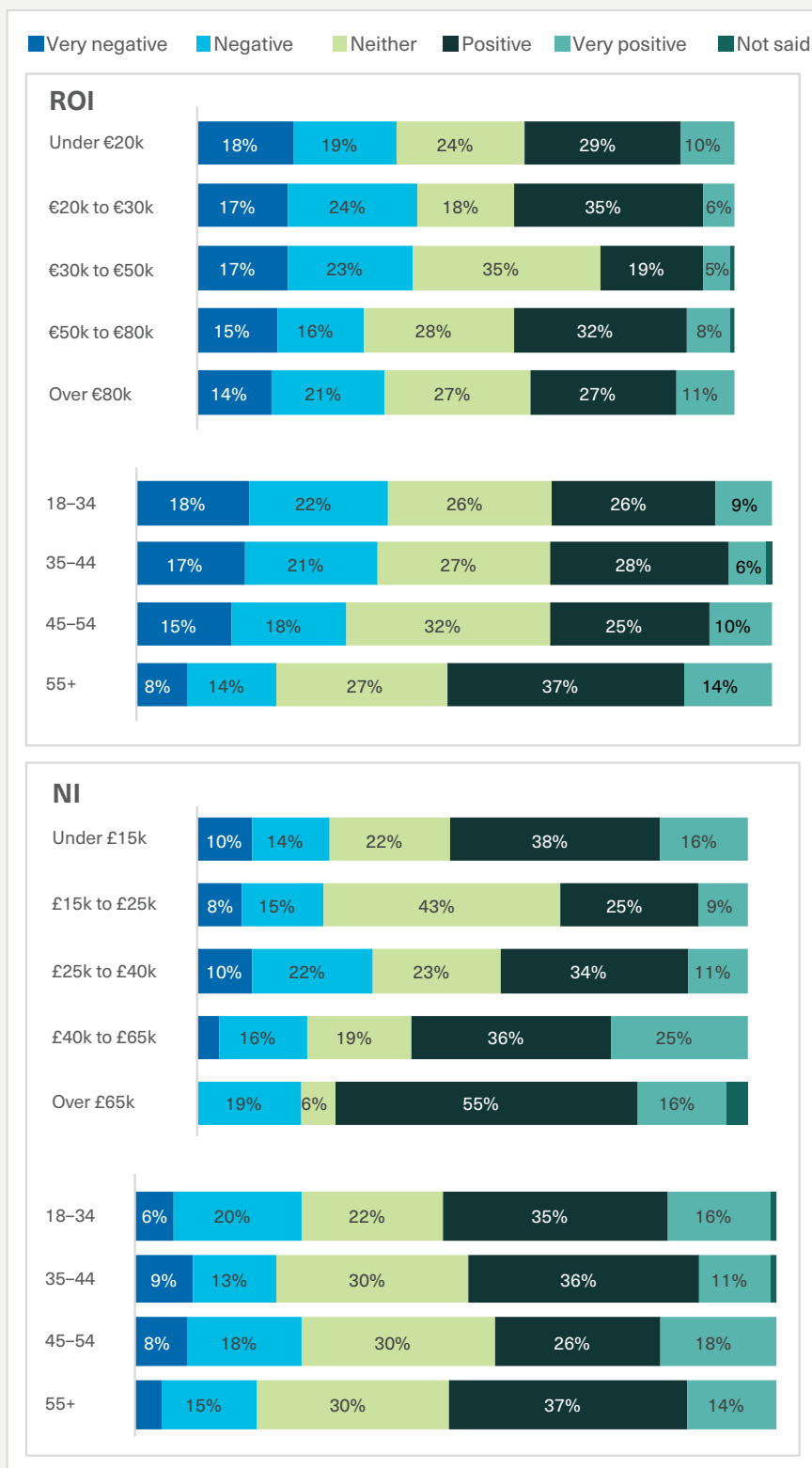
In ROI, younger renters tend to be more dissatisfied. In contrast, those on higher incomes in NI tend to be more positive about their experience in the private rental sector.

⁵³ <https://data.cso.ie/table/FY034B>

⁵⁴ <https://www.nisra.gov.uk/publications/census-2021-main-statistics-housing-and-accommodation-tables>

⁵⁵ McKee, K., Moore-Cherry, N., & Gray, N. (2023). Generation rent and the new urban precarity: Housing, class and inequality in contemporary Ireland. *Urban Studies*, 60(12), 2321–2338.

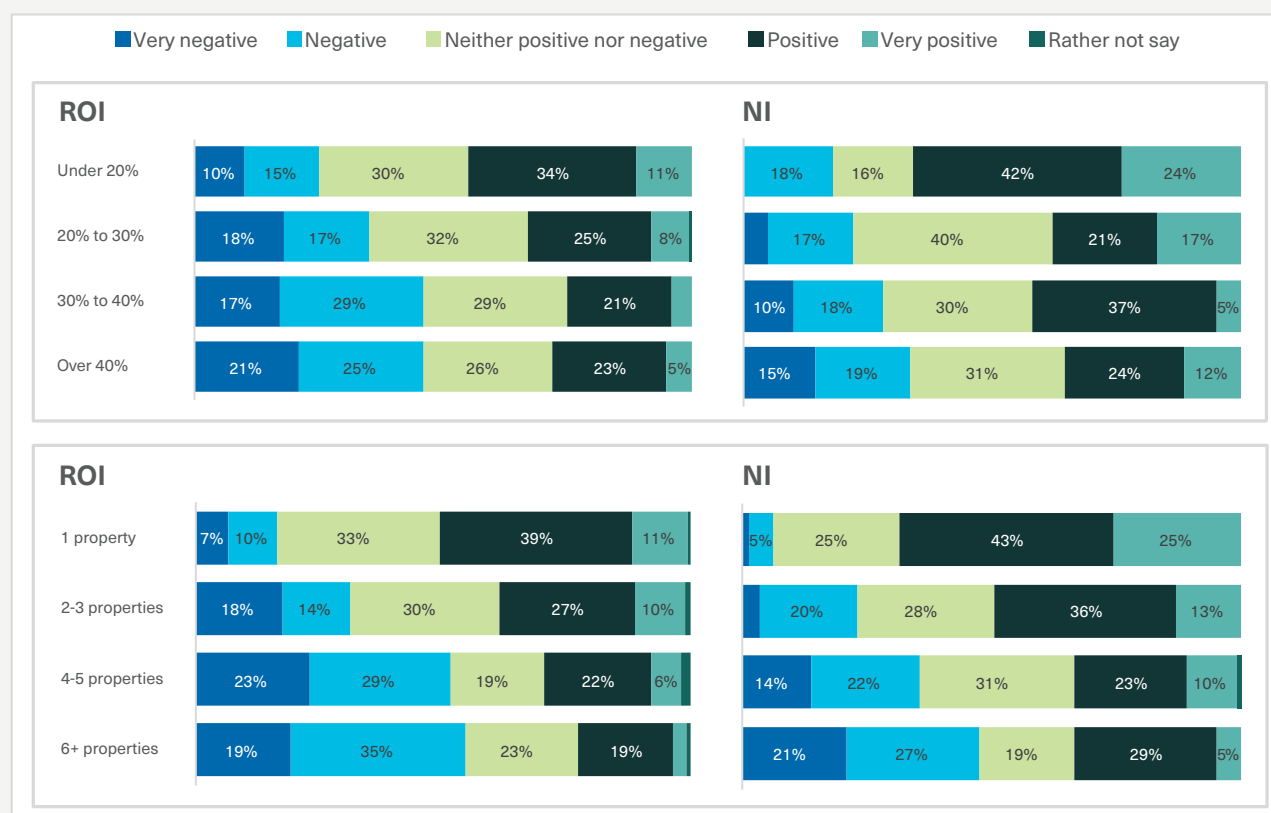
Figure 33. Overall experience of the private rental sector in the Republic of Ireland (ROI) and Northern Ireland (NI) broken down by age and income.



The relationship between age and overall experience is not as strong as the relationship between the number of properties the tenant has lived in. The more properties one has inhabited, the more dissatisfied one tends to be with the rental market. This feature is very prominent, illustrating the presence of two distinct types of tenants: those in stable tenancies with landlords they are satisfied with – often considering themselves lucky – and those in more unpredictable arrangements.

The close relationship between satisfaction and income is even clearer when we estimate the share of net income spent on rent for each type of renter, from those with a very positive experience to those with a very negative experience. Here we can clearly see a powerful relationship among NI renters. In NI, those with a ‘very negative’ experience spend an average 41% of their net income on rent, whereas those with a ‘very positive’ experience spend an average 28% of their net income on rent. In ROI, this particular variable has weaker predictive capacity.

Figure 34. Overall experience of renting broken down by number of properties rented and share of net income spent on rent



Again, experiences of damp or mould also appear to shape renters' attitudes towards the sector. Those in ROI who report damp or mould in their homes are much more negative: 52% are either negative or very negative and 21% see their experience as positive or very positive. In NI, the results are less clear-cut, with 44% negative and 28% positive.

Former renters

When current homeowners in ROI were asked a similar set of questions about their experience of the private rental sector, a clear contrast emerged between their experience and that of current renters. Homeowners in ROI rated their previous experiences in the private rental sector more positively overall, with 42% describing it as either positive or very positive, compared to 35% of current renters. There was also a lower incidence of negative experiences, with 21% of homeowners reporting negative experiences compared with 36% of current renters.

Finding rental accommodation also appears to have been considerably less difficult for those who now own their own home, with 43% recalling some level of difficulty in finding rental accommodation compared with 93% of current renters.

In addition, homeowners reported higher levels of security in rental tenure, and when asked to list the main challenges they faced while renting, the most frequent response was that they had experienced no issues (43%), followed by lack of security of tenure (28%), unaffordable rent (25%) and poor living conditions (15%). This group described having positive relationships with previous landlords at rates similar to those reported by current renters.

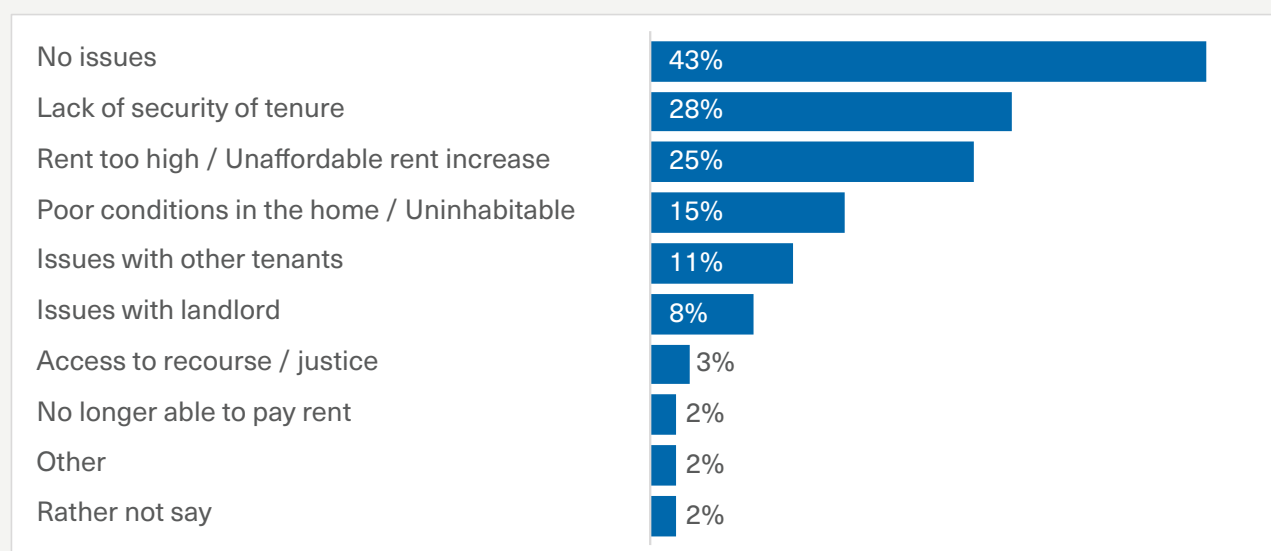
Those who have since been able to attain homeownership status reported vastly superior experiences with their current housing situation compared to their time in the private rental sector. Nearly three-quarters (72%) report that their current overall housing situation is much better, with 21% reporting it is somewhat better, 5% saying it is about the same, and only 1% defining it as worse. These satisfaction rates mirror those reported in the Residential Satisfaction in Ireland survey,⁵⁶ where 93% of homeowners describe very high satisfaction with their current housing situation compared with 82% of private renters.

Perceptions of affordability are a lot higher after transitioning to homeownership. When they were asked how affordable they found their current housing costs compared to the cost of previous rentals, 35% of homeowners described them as very affordable, 41% as affordable, 14% as neutral, 7% as expensive and 2% as very expensive. The broader

⁵⁶ The Housing Agency. Anne Murphy (2024). Residential satisfaction in Ireland 2023. National study of housing experiences, attitudes and aspirations in Ireland. Dublin: The Housing Agency. <https://www.housingagency.ie/sites/default/files/2024-04/Residential%20Satisfaction%20in%20Ireland%202023.pdf>

literature supports the findings of our research. The Residential Satisfaction in Ireland survey found that 28% of private renters struggle to pay rent compared with only 10% of mortgage holders. Similarly, another study by Waldon et al., (2025) found that, between 2020-2022, 31% of private renters experienced medium-to-high levels of energy precarity, as opposed to 3.7% of mortgage holders.⁵⁷

Figure 35. Main issues faced by homeowners when living in private rental sector – ‘What were the main challenges you faced while renting privately? (Select all that apply)’



⁵⁷ Waldron, R., Sugrue, S., Simcock, N. and Holloway, L. (2025). Precarious lives: Exploring the intersection of insecure housing and energy conditions in Ireland. *Energy Research & Social Science*, 121. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.erss.2025.103992>

What would make renting better

Survey respondents were asked to give longer-form text responses in relation to what they believed would improve housing. We can classify responses into six broad changes that would improve the rental experience on the island:

Affordability: As seen throughout this research, across the island, over half of respondents (58%) spend more than 30% of their gross yearly income on rent. Suggestions from survey respondents included: “rent caps”, “freezes”, “price ceilings” or an overarching “make rent cheaper to make renting an overall more positive experience”.

Availability: The pressure to find accommodation weighs heavily in responses across income categories, community, age or location, with 64% of total respondents stating that it is very difficult to find accommodation. Survey respondents suggested some solutions to address the lack of housing, including: “building more accommodation”, “converting derelicts back”, “vacancy tax”, “densifying” and “limiting short-term lets”.

Public Housing: With both high costs and high demand, respondents believe that adding more public/social housing, such as rent-to-buy/intermediate rent and renters’ co-ops, would ease the tension in the rental market.

Security of Tenure: Expanding tenancy rights, especially that around lease lengths and notice periods, would reduce the insecurity many renters feel throughout rental occupancy. Worry around sudden no-fault eviction notices creates consistent stressors surrounding housing security, and respondents believe that the expansion of these tenancy rights would increase housing security

Standards: With a high rate of respondents (59%) across the island reporting maintenance issues in their house, and only 15% of respondents stating that issues were resolved after contacting the landlord, renters believe that increasing the minimum rental standards will ensure a better living environment for the rental sector. Respondents’ suggestions included increasing inspections, expediting repairs, enforcing minimum standards or introducing an “NCT (or MOT) for rentals”.

Conclusions

This study offers a comparative view of renting across the island. Using a large, weighted survey (n=1,380) alongside in-depth interviews, we outline the strong aspirations for homeownership, the constrained pathways to achieve that, and everyday precarity in the private rented sector that differs in degree between ROI and NI.

Aspirations and expectations

It is clear that most renters would prefer to own within five years, yet only about a third expect to get there. Expectations are notably more pessimistic in ROI, with NI tenants being more expectant and hopeful of being allocated a social home. A separate ROI subsample of former renters now living with parents shows how affordability pressures push people out of the market altogether and, for many, toward emigration.

Security of tenure and churn

Uncertainty is widespread and higher in ROI. Two issues dominate: unaffordable rents/rent increases and fear of landlord-initiated termination. Churn is greater in ROI (shorter average time per property and more moves), amplifying instability. Vulnerability is concentrated among single-parent households and older renters, with dramatic differences between young cohorts across ROI and NI.

Access, rights and enforcement

Finding accommodation is difficult island-wide, but exceptionally so in ROI, where requirements lean heavily on references; NI leans more on guarantors, particularly for younger renters. Knowledge of rights is “good enough” in outline but weaker on procedures (rent reviews, notice, dispute routes), and interviewees often adopt a pragmatic “don’t poke the bear” stance that suppresses complaints even when rights are known, illustrating an enforcement gap rather than a pure information problem.

Affordability and financial pressure

On average, tenants spend approximately 37% of their net income on rent in ROI and 32% in NI. While arrears levels are similar, the drivers differ: unexpected bills and rent increases are more prominent in ROI; family changes and relationship breakdowns are more impactful in NI. In ROI, HAP only partially cushions shocks: ineligibility at modest incomes, reliance on top-ups, and a shrinking pool of homes within HAP limits expose households to ongoing stress. These dynamics erode savings, force household budget cutbacks and push some into living back with parents or considering exit from the country.

Repairs, quality and deposits

Damp/mould and heating costs are very common, particularly in ROI. Responses to repairs are uneven, with short-term fixes prevalent. In many cases, renters avoid raising issues with landlords for fear of repercussions. Deposit practices show a sharp policy contrast: NI's statutory deposit protection is embedded; ROI still lacks an operational scheme. The concept, however, is very popular in ROI. Despite this difference, about three in ten renters report past problems with deposit retention.

Implications

- **Stabilise tenancies:** In ROI, strengthen enforcement of existing rent-increase rules and accelerate pathways that limit no-fault terminations in practice; in NI, reduce reliance on indefinite periodic tenancies by improving notice, documentation and minimum protections.
- **Adopt proven safeguards:** Implement a statutory deposit protection scheme in ROI, mirroring NI's model, with independent holding and mandatory mediation processes; tighten compliance monitoring in NI.
- **Target affordability where it bites:** Update HAP parameters and enforce a prohibition on informal top-ups; pair with cost-rental/social supply growth to give credible non-market options.
- **Protect high-risk groups:** Tailor supports for single parents (childcare-aware housing supports) and older renters (energy upgrades, modification grants, predictable rents and secure long-term leases).
- **Move from rights on paper to rights in use:** Resource inspection and dispute bodies to reduce the burden on tenant self-reporting; provide simple, trusted, one-stop channels for advice and redress.

The island's rental sector is carrying more of the housing system than it was built to bear. Tenants need predictable rents, enforceable security and credible alternatives to precarious private renting. Many of the remedies are known and already working somewhere on the island; the task now is to apply them consistently and at scale.

Renting on the Island of Ireland

An All-Island Survey of Private Rented Sector Tenants

Dr. Kevin Cunningham

Ben Heskin

January 2026



Revenue (Charities Unit) (CHY): 6279
Charities Regulatory Authority (CRA):
200110301

Housing Rights

The Charity Commission for Northern Ireland
Charity Number: 105735



Riailas na hÉireann
Government of Ireland



The Scheme to Support National Organisations is funded by the
Government of Ireland through the Department of Rural and
Community Development.

978-1-0687035-2-2

ISBN 978-1-0687035-2-2



9 781068 703522 >